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# DIARIES OF MY OLDER SISTER

**Depression and Suicide  
in Korea, Asia and America**

By TERRY BU

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Diaries of My Older Sister:  
Depression and Suicide in Korea, Asia and America  
by Terry Bu  
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# Preface



My sister Katie committed suicide in her college dorm room a few months before her 21st birthday.

When she was alive, Katie was deemed the model eldest Asian daughter, the quintessential example of the “model minority.” She was an overachieving straight-A student pursuing her double-major STEM degree at a top university on full scholarship. Because of her maturity, intelligence and caring personality, Katie was a great role model for not just me but also for many friends who knew her. She loved singing acapella, writing poetry, drawing and plant collecting. Nobody could tell from looking at Katie that she had been secretly suffering from crippling depression, bulimia and low self-esteem for most of her young adult life.

Prior to her suicide, Katie had been seeing a campus psychiatrist for several months after a romantic breakup. Her friends on campus had been quite worried about her visibly changed, thin appearance and mood changes. Her diaries indicate that she was forcing herself on an extreme diet only eating one apple a day and then filling herself up with water. On one particular afternoon, she received a C- on her biochemistry midterm exam. Katie was the type of person who could not stand anything less than perfection from herself and always tried to meet the high expectations of being the model Asian daughter. She might have been in a particularly vulnerable mental state that day, with her relationship issues and eating disorders compounded on top of this incident. According to Katie’s friend who had talked to her earlier that afternoon, this exam score might have felt devastating for her and pushed her over the edge.

By the time Katie’s roommate discovered her in her room with a plastic bag over her head, she had been without oxygen for way too long. I still clearly remember the night when my mother and

I received a call from the school hospital telling us that Katie had tried to hang herself. Katie was taken to the ICU where she fell into a deep coma and diagnosed with severe, irreversible brain damage. She spent her last weeks in the hospital hooked up to a life support machine while my mother, a few close family friends and I prayed for a miracle. After months of no noticeable improvement, we were forced to agree with the doctors to turn off her life support.

The rest of the world seemed to move on after Katie's death, but it wasn't easy for me or my mother. After her death, her campus psychiatrist sat us down and said, "Katie suffered from severe depression due to her oversensitive personality. Medications did not seem to help her. We are sorry." I remember angrily thinking, "That's it? That's the best explanation you could come up with?" I could not believe that was the extent of their knowledge. My sister's death definitely deserved a better explanation than that.

Katie and I had been very close and were almost inseparable when we were little, spending all of our childhood years together. Over the last 15 years, as her younger brother who loved her deeply, I have tried to unravel the truth behind why Katie might have been so compelled to commit suicide. It just didn't make any sense to me—a person as intelligent as her deciding to throw away her own life at such a young age. I studied the nature of depression and reviewed Katie's handwritten diaries that she had kept since she was 12 years old. I analyzed her writings carefully, hoping to gain more insight into the inner workings of her mind, thoughts and emotions while she was alive.



Me and Katie growing up in South Korea and Japan

And what I started to realize, 15 years after her death, is that no single person or event might have been to blame. I strongly believe that Katie's suicide was not just an isolated event based only on her specific circumstances, but the result of a very noticeable general pattern related to depression and suicide worldwide. This may be a

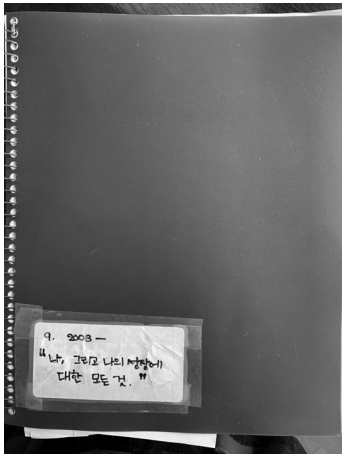
trend that has particularly impacted demographics such as South Koreans, Asian-Americans and young adults in the U.S.

Research in psychology shows that there is a strong connection between our mental narrative and depression. “Mental narrative” in this context means the stories you tell yourself in your own mind and the way you talk to yourself, commonly referred to as your internal dialogue or self-talk. According to a study published in *Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience* in 2016, “maladaptive rumination” or the act of repetitively thinking negative and distressing thoughts about one’s life is one of the most common tell-tale causes of depression.<sup>1</sup> Certain personality traits such as perfectionism, neuroticism and excessive focus on relational status (how you compare to others) all contribute to this harmful mental habit and are most commonly found in chronic depressive patients.<sup>2</sup> Katie had clearly expressed similar thought patterns in her own diaries and in her interactions with others when she was alive. Katie used to think of herself as fat, ugly, broken and stupid, when in fact, she was talented, beautiful and intelligent.

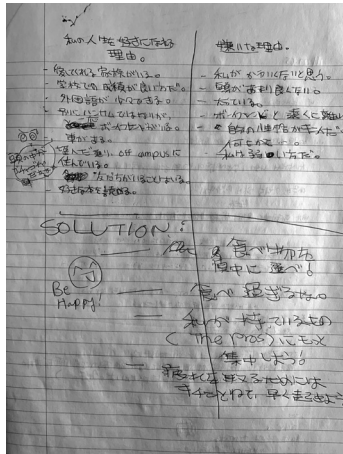
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1 Ordaz, S. J. et al. (2016). “Ruminative brooding is associated with salience network coherence in early pubertal youth.” *Social Cognitive and Affective Neuroscience*, 12(2): 298-310. doi:10.1093/scan/nsw133.

2 Nepon, T., Flett, G. L., Hewitt, P. L., & Molnar, D. S. (2011). Perfectionism, negative social feedback, and interpersonal rumination in depression and social anxiety. *Canadian Journal of Behavioural Science / Revue canadienne des sciences du comportement*, 43(4): 297-308.



Left: One of Katie's last diary notebooks she kept until her death



Right: A page from her diary. In the right column, Katie lists out the reasons she dislikes herself, “stupid, weak, fat, unlikable and not cute.” In the left column, she lists her positive qualities such as having a loving family and good grades in school. It shows her final attempts to remain positive despite her frequent, self-loathing rumination

10.15.05

오늘 좀더 강한 사람이 되어야지.

어제보다 더그럽게

내일보다 여유있게

하지만 누구보다도 오늘의 이 한순간을 보람있게

살아가는 내가 되어야지

나를 아껴주는 이들이 있다

어디에나, 어디에나

나는 외톨이가 아니다

내가 외로운 이유는 바로 내가 어리석기 때문이다.

괴로운 생각은 접어 버리고, 오늘 하루만큼은

다들 오지 않을 이 소중한 하루를 확실하게

살아가는 내가 되어야지.

One of Katie's diary entries in Korean. Translation: "I will try to be a little stronger person today. I want to live every day and every moment the best I can. There are people who value me, I am not alone; the reason I feel lonely is because I'm too stupid to realize that. I need to stop thinking painful thoughts. I will live today as best as I can because today is precious and will not come back."

The insights I gathered from Katie's diaries led me to ask if others suffer from similar thought patterns. The answer was a resounding yes. A 2009 research study published by the University of Maryland School of Public Health found a pattern of strong mental stress among Asian-American young adults in terms of "pressure to meet parental expectations of high academic achievement", "living up to the model minority stereotype", "difficulty of balancing two different cultures and communicating with parents", and "discrimination or isolation due to racial or cultural background."<sup>3</sup> The Anxiety and Depression Association of America also reports that Asian-Americans are three times less likely than their non-Asian counterparts to seek treatment for their mental health concerns because "doing so would admit the existence of a mental health disorder, and in turn would bring shame to their family's name by appearing weak or imperfect."<sup>4</sup>

Traditional Asian cultures have long indoctrinated their people to value academic performance, high social status and professional advancement as top priorities in life. But our community has not been successful in prioritizing the importance of mental health awareness, emotional intelligence or helping younger generations develop a strong sense of self-love or self-identity first. This might have been the case with Katie as well. She never learned that caring about her own mental health and changing the way she thought about herself were just as important as getting good grades in school or achieving "success" in the eyes of others. She

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3 Lee, Sunmin et al. (2009). "Model minority at risk: expressed needs of mental health by Asian American young adults." *Journal of Community Health*, 34(2): 144-52. doi:10.1007/s10900-008-9137-1.

4 "Asian-Americans." Anxiety and Depression Association of America, ADAA [adaa.org/asian-americans](http://adaa.org/asian-americans).

silently pursued the Asian vision of “success,” suffered quietly by herself like a mature older Asian daughter and then died quietly in her dorm room.

We are also not the only South Korean or American family that has directly or indirectly experienced the effects of depression and suicide. It’s been reported that South Korea has the highest suicide rate among the OECD (Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development) member countries of the world. Many high-profile South Korean celebrities, musicians and even a former president have committed suicide over the recent years, citing reasons such as shame, guilt, self-loathing and social pressure. In the United States, suicide rates among teens and young adults regardless of race have reached their highest point in nearly two decades with an annual increase of 10% between 2014 to 2017 according to the U.S. News & World Report in 2019.<sup>5</sup> Also, a 2018 report from the Blue Cross Blue Shield Association found that diagnoses of major depression among its patient members swelled by 33% between 2013 to 2016 for all adults, 63% for teens and 47% for millennials.<sup>6</sup> “We are concerned that depression rates are continuing to accelerate, and we need to do more work to identify the underlying cause,” says Dr. Trent Haywood, MD, a former Senior Vice President and Chief Medical Officer for the Blue Cross Blue Shield Association.

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5 Thompson, Dennis. (2019, June 18). “U.S. youth suicide rate reaches 20-year high.” U.S. News & World Report. <https://www.usnews.com/news/health-news/articles/2019-06-18/us-youth-suicide-rate-reaches-20-year-high>. Accessed June 20, 2019.

6 “Major Depression: The Impact on Overall Health.” Blue Cross Blue Shield Association. May 18, 2018. <https://www.bcbs.com/the-health-of-america/reports/major-depression-the-impact-overall-health>. Accessed August 23, 2019.

I wrote this book to remind everyone that our understanding of clinical depression as well as our cultural definition of “success” must evolve to create a healthier and more balanced mental narrative for people all over the world. The Asian-American and South Korean communities in particular are great examples of the damage that can stem from a distorted mental narrative on a societal scale. In a culture that considers lagging behind your peers in academic, professional or personal achievements a cause for great shame and disappointment, there is bound to be mental turmoil among its people, especially young adults who are emotionally sensitive and susceptible to external influence.

The first section of this book covers the different types of harmful mental habits that people vulnerable to depression are likely to engage in and how they manifest in the form of automatic, repetitive thoughts in your mind. These thoughts then may cause people to suffer from a stressful mental activity called “rumination” which is well-documented in psychology as a precursor to major depression. The second section covers the possible origins behind how and why our mind creates these stories. We will cover the impact of childhood experiences, parental upbringing, cultural influences, social media, peer pressure, neurochemistry and more. The last section discusses the possible strategies we can employ to change our mindset going forward as individuals and also collectively as a society.

I don’t claim to be a certified expert on mental illnesses. I definitely do not have all the answers myself. I think of myself more as a messenger of the already existing, complex knowledge out there regarding these topics, and this book is my attempt at distilling

that body of knowledge and current findings for you so that the general public can elevate their level of understanding. I do consider myself a committed student and a first-hand observer of the nature of depression because of how dramatically it has impacted me and my family. But I also encourage you to think objectively about the ideas in these pages, challenge them if necessary and verify the truth for yourself. If this book can guide a few of you into having a better understanding of depression and of how you can help yourself and others, it will have achieved its purpose. I look forward to sharing this story with you. We thank you wholeheartedly for reading our book.



From left: Me, Mom and Katie. Connecticut 2003



# I: Observing Our Mind's Stories

Causes of depression can be highly complex, difficult to pinpoint and specific to the individual. Nevertheless, researchers have found a strong link between depression and our mind's automatic negative thoughts, or the habitual stories we repeat to ourselves. The academic term for this type of mental activity is "rumination." Based on my sister's diaries as well as my own research and experience, the following types of rumination may be commonly shared among depressed individuals as well as those at risk for depression. Observing our own mind for such types of thinking patterns may be crucial for maintaining a healthy mind.

## Chapter 1

# “I am not good enough”

When you look at yourself in the mirror, what do you see? Do you see somebody amazing in your eyes?

All my childhood, I looked up to my older sister like a JV basketball player on the bench looking up to the captain of the Varsity team. She was a straight-A student, spoke English, Japanese and Korean perfectly by age 16 and had numerous talents like singing, writing and drawing. In college, she double-majored in Marine Biology and Environmental Science with ambitions of studying Neuroscience. She won poetry competitions and was elected president of multiple extracurricular clubs. Compared to her, I felt like a stumbling little idiot throughout my childhood and relied on her for anything even remotely difficult such as homework. One of the reasons I started being a class clown and telling more jokes as a kid was I felt it was the only way I could stand apart from Katie. My parents and relatives all used to say that Katie was the smart, responsible and mature one, and I was the rambunctious, awkward little brother.

But Katie's diaries tell a different story. For as long as she was alive, Katie had been under the impression that she was not good enough. Not pretty enough. Not thin enough. Not smart enough. Not socially vibrant enough. Not talented enough. She wrote frequently about how much she hated herself and all the negative qualities that she saw in herself. In high school, she seemed to

have been particularly hurt and distressed when her boyfriend at the time would talk to other girls in her presence and immediately concluded, “Oh, I must be a really boring person and he must be tired of me already.” Katie was always very hard on herself, not giving herself enough credit for her numerous qualities and achievements.

One of the most harmful mental habits is this tendency to talk negatively about ourselves and to talk down to ourselves. This kind of thinking is especially common in Asian families where parents literally say “You are not good enough” to kids unless they get straight As on their report cards. When this kind of self-critical mindset bleeds into other parts of your life so that you constantly feel inadequate about yourself, mental stress may not be far behind. This mindset is also quite prevalent in people vulnerable to depression. Because they carry this enormous burden thinking they are not “good enough” at all times, they might resort to perfectionism or look for ways to overcompensate for these imagined deficiencies. Or they might even choose to resort to escapism or temporary pleasures to disguise their painful feelings of inadequacy.

I pray that you do not let this particular mental demon lead you astray. You were born “good enough” regardless of your intelligence, looks, talents or achievements. We must not obsess over our imperfections, especially because every single one of us is imperfect in one way or another. The very belief that you are not “enough” unless you meet certain qualifications in life is extremely flawed. Others may judge you for this quality or that quality and try to tell you that you do not meet some imaginary criteria that are important in their own mind. In fact, your own mind can sometimes be your own worst judge and constant, harsh critic.

Oftentimes, you must tune them out.

When we decide to see the beauty in ourselves despite our imperfections, we will soon begin to see beauty everywhere—in our lives and the world at large. Granted, this kind of mental perspective is not easy to change overnight, but it's important to keep reminding yourself on a daily basis that you truly are good enough. You always have been good enough. Any future effort to improve yourself then doesn't have to come from a place of "wanting to be good enough." Instead, it will come from your genuine curiosity and passion for whatever action you decide to engage yourself in. If Katie were alive today, I would try to remind her as often as possible about all the beautiful qualities that she possessed, and perhaps help her stop obsessing about all the imperfections she saw in herself. Her lovely cooking skills. Her amazing voice. Her friendly personality. How smart she was. Although it's too late for me to say anything like that to Katie, I now try to be more encouraging toward others and also toward myself. I am good enough, you are good enough, and as long as we are doing our best to become better everyday, that really is good enough. And by being more liberal with our compliments whenever we see other people trying their best, we may be able to make the world a slightly less judgmental place, and fill it with more acceptance and love.

One practical exercise I want to suggest is keeping a daily journal of your biggest strengths and accomplishments. Go buy a notebook and write down every morning (or every night) a short list of your positive qualities and recent "wins" that made you feel good about yourself. Any small wins will do; they don't always have to be major achievements like getting promoted or acing

your midterm exam. These can be private victories that still make you feel good no matter how small. For example, the extra effort you made to cook dinner last night even though you felt tired after work. Or an act of kindness you showed to your work colleague who was struggling with a project. Or the way you assertively stood up to somebody. Then as time goes on, engaging your mind repeatedly in this “wins” journal will serve as an oasis for your self-love and help build you up. By reminding yourself daily about the victorious moments you’ve had in the past when you felt the most joyous, happy, successful, intelligent and proud, you are able to relive those feelings once again in the present moment and feel like a winner again. Otherwise, in our busy lives, it’s easy for us to lose sight of ourselves and encounter negative influences or people in our environment who are quick to point out whenever we mess up or make us feel like we are not “good enough.” We must effectively build our own mental barriers inside our mind against such influences, and this journal is a good example of that.

And once you can recall with absolute ease those past moments where you flourished with your wonderful qualities, nobody can take them away from you. They will be yours forever. Hold onto those memories like precious gems, because that’s really what they are. Rare gems for your soul.

## Chapter 2

# **“I am so ugly and unattractive”**

Katie used to believe she was ugly. Growing up, she particularly hated her dark-skinned complexion, which both Katie and I inherited from my mother's side of the family. In traditional South Korean culture, dark skin is not always considered an attractive physical trait, and generally speaking, young women prefer having white, porcelain-like skin. This leads them to spend an exorbitant amount of money on skin care and makeup products that make them look whiter. My mother, sister and I all used to share the same inferiority complex about our skin color because so many Koreans had made fun of us in the past. In Katie's group of female Asian friends, they would always try to look lighter and prettier like the celebrities on TV. I don't think Katie ever learned to love her skin and appearance. In her diary entries before her death, she even called herself a “dark, ugly duckling.”

In South Korea, there is a huge demand for plastic surgery—from both men and women—which has made Seoul the world's “plastic surgery capital.” Business Insider reports that, at nearly 1 million procedures a year, South Korea has the highest rate of cosmetic surgery in the world, and 1 in 3 South Korean women between the ages of 19 and 29 may have now had plastic sur-

gery.<sup>7</sup> Many people decide to treat this simply as a “cultural phenomenon,” but I can’t help but wonder if there’s any underlying problems in a culture where young adults become obsessed with looking better and prettier through any means necessary. Plastic surgery may help young adults resolve their appearance-based insecurities from the “outside-in” instead of the much more difficult “inside-out.” Granted, the latter approach is much harder and requires building up one’s self-acceptance from the ground-up. It may even require constantly reminding ourselves that smaller eyes, a smaller nose, or darker skin color are all completely okay and not “ugly.” But I doubt that highly lucrative plastic surgery clinics making their big bucks will remind you to “strengthen your inner self-acceptance” in their poster ads.

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7 Baer, Drake. (2015, September 22). “Why South Korea is the plastic surgery capital of the world.” Business Insider. [www.businessinsider.com/south-korea-is-the-plastic-surgery-capital-of-the-world-2015-9](http://www.businessinsider.com/south-korea-is-the-plastic-surgery-capital-of-the-world-2015-9).



The three physical features described above, including double eyelids, prominent nose bridge, and fair skin, are high in demand by young South Korean adults

In a world where beauty standards are thrust upon us from all angles via television, social media and advertising, it becomes almost impossible to hold on to what makes you unique and to think of yourself as beautiful. But what makes someone “beautiful” is often changing, incredibly subjective and open to interpretation. I think about Katie and all the young adults who might be self-conscious about their physical appearance and cannot help but be angry at the external influences that might have negatively impacted their self-perception. As cliché as this sounds, the constant messages we receive from advertising, television, Hollywood and social media affect our perspectives significantly and often negatively. And today’s media creators who produce videos, shows and movies can sometimes be incredibly irresponsible with the messages they send to young adults (who then soak them like sponges) since they are incentivized to create shocking or visual content that easily grab public attention, and not at all incentivized

to think about the psychological effects they may spread to their viewers.

If it were up to me, I would remind you that you are beautiful, no matter what you look like. Every single person in the world is born beautiful, just as you are. God would tell you the same thing. Please don't let anybody tell you any different. At the risk of sounding like an old grandpa, your external appearance is not nearly as important as the inner beauty that you cultivate inside your mind, such as your values, wisdom, passion and compassion for others. External beauty also fades with time while inner beauty does not. Granted, there are things that we can realistically do to improve our external appearance such as keeping a healthy diet, exercising, taking care of our skin and dressing better but at a certain point, we must limit how much focus we give to our appearances. If you are concerned that others won't take notice of you because you are not physically attractive enough, I want you to know that the right people will take notice of you for the right reasons regardless of your physical beauty.

## Chapter 3

# “I am so behind compared to others”



Competitiveness is ingrained in all of us. As a kid, I would become upset with my friends whenever they beat me at games like poker or basketball. Now that I'm older, I look at a friend who owns her house and think "Wow, so impressive. I'm so behind than her." I look at someone who's been promoted to VP at a major corporation and think "Wow, VP at 30. I'm so behind."

Comparison is this endless losing game. Anybody can find somebody else who's better at something than they are. I may be better than my friend at playing the guitar but he may be better than me at running marathons. So does that mean only one of us is deserving of love and respect? Surely, that's ridiculous. But this kind of "comparison-based thinking" happens all the time, and we suffer a great deal from this mindset unless we learn to control it. Obsessing about your own status in comparison to others and

“where you stand” in relation to others can be a common trigger for stressful rumination and harmful overthinking. What’s even worse is that when people around you are being competitive, their competitive thoughts and feelings can trigger your own competitive nature.

Katie seemed to play this comparison game a lot when she was growing up. She would get visibly upset if I performed better than her at certain activities like playing golf or computer programming. It made me want to yell at her, “Katie, you are better than me in so many other ways. You have so many other talents like drawing and singing. Why are you so upset that I am better at these few other frivolous things?” Her diaries show that she engaged in the same comparison-based thinking when it came to her peers in high school and college. “Oh, she is more interesting than me. I’m nothing like that,” or “Oh, he went to a better school than me. I’m nothing compared to that.” All that comparison thinking seemed to get her down a lot.

I’ve known many South Korean and Asian-American peers who strongly exhibit this comparison mentality. Asian parents seem to be literally born with the disease of comparing their children to other children as if all that comparing is going to actually help the kids achieve more or become mentally stronger. South Koreans actually have a term for this called “엄친아” (pronounced Um-Chin-Ah which translates literally to “your mother’s friend’s son”) when your mom constantly compares you to her friend’s son or daughter who’s doing a lot better than you in life. For example, “Hey son, did you hear Jane’s son is now making lots of money as a doctor, living in a luxury apartment and traveling all the time? She must be so proud of him. When are you going to

be more like him?” is something you might typically hear during a dinner conversation. When I was a kid, I would listen to these comments so seriously and internalize all of them, which then filled me up with a mix of competitive anger and disappointment in my own status. Nowadays, I interrupt her and say, “Mom. I have my life. He has his.”

Many Asian parents erroneously believe this kind of comparison can be used as motivation to push their children further. Although I do not blame parents for wanting the best for their children, they are incredibly unaware of the anger and self-hatred they can impart to their children if this kind of comparison-mentality becomes frequent. The competitive nature that exists in all of us is fueled even more by our parents who are basically pouring gasoline on a wildfire. Granted, we have to appreciate the fact that most of the time, our parents are just trying to nudge us toward the right direction with no knowledge of any potential harm. However, even they don't realize that unhelpful mental narratives may then trickle down into the children's psyche who may end up compensating by constantly trying to prove they are better than others or obsess over falling behind. As hard as it may be for our parents to admit, we must sometimes block out their influence for the sake of our own mental health. In fact, if you notice that another person's influence on your psyche and mental narrative might be significantly harmful (for example, people who aggravate your competitive nature over small things), it may be wise to reconsider that relationship.

We can learn to harness our competitive nature instead of letting it drive us crazy or obsess about how we compare to others. I am not encouraging that you don't push yourself to perform at your best or stop caring about competition altogether. But no-

tice how easy it is for us to get fixated on “beating others.” Being overly competitive tends to make us lose sight of what’s truly important. For example, if you are playing a basketball game with your friends, is it more important to hog the ball and prove yourself as the best player in your group, or to enjoy a great time with everyone and share the ball instead of keeping score? If you are constantly being competitive with a particular coworker, is your competitiveness contributing to the company as a whole, or is it needlessly stressing everyone out? If you obsess over beating your friend’s exam score in class, are you actually paying attention to the material that you should be learning?

Comparing yourself to others may only serves a useful purpose if you can then apply that information for a useful purpose. Perhaps to gauge how far you’ve come in some aspect of your life. Professional athletes often use competition to motivate themselves to perform better and to learn from their rivals. However, you must not let it consume you. Choose to free yourself from the game of constant comparison. Watch out when others try to pull you into a competitive mode by trying to one-up you or showing you how they are better than you every chance they get. Spend your thoughts and energy on becoming the best you that you can be. Use that competitive drive for you instead of against you by daring to be better than you were yesterday and committing to improving yourself daily. People who are capable of great focus and mastering difficult skills are proficient at being in the “zone” or the “flow state” where their brain is 100% immersed in whatever task they are mastering at the time, instead of being distracted by competitors, haters or naysayers. It’s almost ironic but in order to compete, you must master your craft, but in order to master

your craft, you must effectively block out all distractions (like your competitors) from your mind.

Lao Tzu, the ancient Chinese philosopher, has a famous proverb that says “大器晚成” (pronounced “dà qì wǎn chéng” in Mandarin) which directly translates to “A large vessel takes a long time to make.” Another translation is “Great talents take a long time to bloom.” When you feel that you are behind in life, remember this proverb. Remember that you are a late bloomer. And when you finally do bloom later in your life—and this will absolutely happen as long as you stay persistent and determined—you will bloom brighter than any other flower the world has ever seen before. Do not wish for an easy life or an early bloom. Your best is yet to come.

## Chapter 4

# **“I should have, I would have, I could have”**

Regret keeps you stuck in the past. I used to be prone to ruminating obsessively over past events and could not stop myself from replaying stressful memories in my head. I often spent hours going over past social situations, recalling hurtful things that other people had said to me and so on. These thoughts would be along the lines of “why did he say that?” or “why did I have to make that stupid mistake?” During many social occasions in my life, others might have thought I must be a very shy person because my brain would be constantly engaged in this frantic mental activity, even in the middle of a party, wedding or an otherwise festive occasion. This mental habit often prevented me from engaging in the present moment without mental distractions or fully opening up to others. Katie and I were similar in this way. We often beat ourselves up over some perceived mistakes and regretted them over and over again in a painful loop.

From the perspective of mental health, rerunning emotionally stressful events over and over in your mind may be extremely counterproductive. When you keep replaying stressful events in your mind, you essentially relive the same negative emotions you felt during the past moment like anger, embarrassment, fear or jealousy, all over again as if they are happening right now. Instead of calm rationality or objectivity that can actually help you learn from the experience and move forward, those intense emotions

can keep you stuck in that past moment as long as the rumination continues. For me, if something upsetting had happened at school earlier in the day, it would ruin my focus and attention for the rest of the evening at home. In turn, I was unable to be present, think of new creative ideas or pay attention to the homework at hand.

The tendency to regret might also be linked to one's perfectionism, which we cover in the next chapter. If you are prone to regretting the "what-ifs" in the past and overthinking about all the possible scenarios to a decision, it may be because you are terrified of having missed out on the "perfect" or optimal answer to a situation. In a way, "regret" might be our own brain's attempt to make sure that we are coming up with the best choices and actions possible when it comes to our social interactions, financial and romantic decisions, or other important opportunities with a significant payoff. So when you are regretting, you are essentially revisiting your past memories to look for things that you could have done better in a retrospective way. Perhaps it's your brain trying to find areas of improvement and learn. However, if you are unable to control this mental habit appropriately, then it may lead to excessive regret, rumination and mental suffering, like Katie and I experienced. It will try to nitpick every single past behavior and situation, and flood your mind with ideas on what you should have done or could have done.

In summary, regretting over the past requires repeatedly recalling stressful memories in your mind, and when you are engaged in this kind of "regret" rumination, you often may not be able to solve the actual problems but instead hammer yourself with negative emotions over and over again. If we engage in this incredibly strenuous mental habit with every frustrating event we

face, how many hours of our precious lives are we going to waste? Mistakes and regrets are bound to happen in life, and if you spend all your time focusing on those things, you will never have the energy to move forward or improve your present moment. The only thing that will help is if you learn something valuable from the past and put that learning into practice in the next opportunity. Forgive yourself. Move on. If you can't extract a solid lesson out of the negative experience, maybe it was meant to be let go. If you are truly overwhelmed by a past event and can't help but obsess about it, talk it out with a trusted friend or a therapist who can help you. The famous Serenity Prayer below has always helped me better accept my past. I include it here for your reference.

“God, grant me the serenity to accept the things I  
cannot change, the courage to change the things I  
can, and the wisdom to know the difference.”

Another practice I'd suggest for controlling your regret rumination is to ask yourself objective questions that help put them into perspective. No matter how significant and painful a recent mistake feels like right now, we have to remind ourselves that it's easy for us to lose perspective and make mountains out of mole-hills when we are still caught up in the emotional intensity of a past event. After you take a few deep breaths to calm yourself down, ask yourself these questions below:

1. Would this mistake matter 5 to 10 years from now?
2. Is continuing to regret about this incident helping me become a better, wiser and happier person or hurting me?

3. Would this mistake matter at your own deathbed? Is this a “life-and-death” issue?

## Chapter 5

# **“I must always be perfect”**

Being vulnerable about our emotions or honestly admitting our problems in front of others is not the strong suit of most Asian families (such as those of Korean, Japanese and Chinese descent). We often never learn the importance of healthy communication to resolve emotional conflicts. In fact, many Asian parents are notoriously incapable of admitting their problems or faults in front of their children. Their sensitive pride and overt avoidance of “losing face” in front of others prevents them from opening up about, well, pretty much anything that might indicate weakness. And this mindset trickles down into the younger generation who then inherits and exhibits that same behavior. And so on goes the never-ending cycle of perfectionism in our culture.

I never understood why Katie never opened up to either me or Mom about her clinical depression or other serious personal issues she was suffering from. We literally had no idea that Katie had been suffering from depression and bulimia until after she committed suicide. Looking back, that’s incredibly sad. In her diaries, Katie often wrote things like “I should be able to deal with all of these problems on my own,” “I shouldn’t have to rely on anyone else with my problems,” and “I am so weak because I can’t solve these problems on my own.” Katie had also been avoiding depression medication, telling herself that “I shouldn’t have to rely on medication because only weak people take medication to solve their problems.”

It is upsetting to think about how stubborn Katie was being, how unwilling to be vulnerable and ask for help. I am not exactly sure where Katie initially learned this habit of never admitting her problems. Was it the Asian influence? Was it her pride? Was it her fear and shame? In her mind, Katie believed she was supposed to be this super-independent woman at the age of 20, one who needed to execute everything perfectly, make no mistakes, and be flawless all on her own.

According to research studies, such perfectionist tendencies are strongly linked to psychological disorders and symptoms such as anxiety, depression, body dissatisfaction, bulimia nervosa, social phobia and suicidal ideation. “Self-oriented perfectionism,” which occurs when “individuals attach irrational importance to being perfect, hold unrealistic expectations of themselves, and are punitive in their self-evaluations,”<sup>8</sup> seems to be correlated with premature death among college students and young people in countries like the U.S., Canada and the U.K. Studies also suggest that “perfectionism is associated with a greater physiological reactivity (e.g., elevated blood pressure) and ill-being in response to life stress and failure”<sup>9</sup> meaning that the same intense focus on being perfect all the time might lead these young people to severe coping difficulties when faced with adult life challenges. The fact that perfectionism and mental illness are linked is not at all surprising given that unrelenting perfectionism can be a perfect recipe for chronic stress.<sup>10</sup>

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8 Sandoiu, Ana. (2018, October 12). “How perfectionism affects your (mental) health.” Medical News Today, <https://www.medicalnewstoday.com/articles/323323.php>.

9 Curran, Thomas. (2017). “Is perfectionism rising over time? A meta-analysis of birth cohort differences from 1989 to 2016.” *American Psychological Association*, 145(4): 410–429, doi:10.31234/osf.io/pkvxa.

10 Flett, Gordon. (2012, February 29). “The price of perfectionism.” Association for Psychological Science. <https://www.psychologicalscience.org/observer/the-price-of-perfectionism>. Accessed March 1, 2019.

We all can benefit from having “high standards” (instead of “perfection”) in our lives so that we can choose to pursue excellence if and when we wish to. However, there has never been any need for any one individual to bear the burden of being perfect in every way. Not only that, improving yourself in any major way takes years of hard work and patience, and you have to remind yourself that “Rome wasn’t built in a day.” You must be willing to endure the discomfort of being imperfect and learn to appreciate your qualities and achievements that are more than good enough. Don’t let the pursuit of perfect blind you from all the abundant blessings in your life that are already great, just as they are. Otherwise, you may continue to suffer from perfectionist obsessions.

Since 2018, I’ve had the privilege of organizing a small discussion group in New York City called JuntoNYC that focuses on group accountability and goal-setting. People from all walks of life gather to talk about self-improvement, achieving our goals and what’s holding us back. My favorite part of our discussions is when we open up about our problems in a judgment-free zone and discuss our “blockers.” We discuss addictions, failed relationships and our lifelong struggles with prioritizing and procrastinating. When you see that other people are suffering from similar problems, and that your problems are not just your own but are shared and addressed by others as well, it helps us open up, connect and bond. It reminds us that we should not be ashamed of our weaknesses, mistakes or imperfections. Although it’s admirable to pursue excellence in everything we do, this journey toward excellence should not make us hate ourselves during the process or lose sight of our mental health. Next time you see a person struggling from their perfectionism, please remind them the truth—that not being perfect has always been okay.

## Chapter 6

# “I am a total failure”

When we experience major setbacks in our lives or fail to get what we want, it's easy for us to lose our perspective. We can become incredibly angry, frustrated and disappointed in such situations. Maybe you bomb your midterm exam and get a C-. Maybe your college application to your dream school gets rejected. Maybe you screw up at your job interview. Maybe you find out your girlfriend or boyfriend is cheating on you. There's an endless list of things that could happen unexpectedly in our lives.

When something like this happens, it literally feels like you just got hit by a truck, and that nothing is ever going to work out for you ever again. You start imagining how bad things are going to be now that this terrible thing has happened. You feel hopeless, dejected and completely dissatisfied with how things are in your life. You might begin to disengage from the world out of pure disappointment from what's been thrown your way. You feel like you will never be able to attain happiness because you just lost your only chance at your dream job, dream relationship, dream school or dream life.

But just because you did badly in one exam doesn't mean that you will be a “failure” or a “loser” for the rest of your life, although you can't help but feel that way. This is a classic example of “catastrophizing,” also known as making mountains out of molehills. Because you are feeling incredibly disappointed and frustrated by what has just happened, the mind is unable to rationally measure

the actual severity of the event. Surely, all those events are upsetting in their own ways. A bad grade might set you back in school. A bad job might be painful for at least a few years. A rejection from your dream school means you have to attend a slightly less prestigious school. But it's Steve Jobs who said "You cannot connect the dots looking forward. You can only connect the dots looking backwards." So whatever tough obstacle or painful trial you are experiencing now, in five or ten years' time, it is highly likely that you will be able to look back at this phase in your life with a sense of appreciation for all the things you learned because of this setback. When things don't go "the way they are supposed to go," you will then be able to take another path in life, which opens up a whole new set of possibilities you couldn't have predicted before. In that way, no "failure" is a true failure. It's just another learning opportunity that takes you closer to your success through an unpredicted journey.

I had one of my most frustrating life experiences when I turned 22 years old and failed to secure a job offer from my dream corporation after graduating from college. Right after the rejection, I truly believed that not getting this job was the worst thing that could have ever happened to me. Many of my peers who graduated from the same business school seemed to be getting offers left and right from prestigious corporations, and I felt like the ugly duckling who got left behind. I was incredibly angry at myself for many years after this happened. At the time, I was unable to understand that this rejection did not mean the end of the world, and that many other opportunities were available in other places that were perfectly conducive for my career growth. But as an entitled, privileged kid at 22, I could only focus on the negative as-

pect of this incident. I was so disappointed and upset at myself for missing this “perfect opportunity” out of college.

But Steve Jobs’s quote turned out to be exactly right. Looking back today to that kid I was ten years ago, I think about how immature and ungrateful I had been. Prior to the time of my graduation, the whole country had been in a severe economic recession, and getting any job at a major corporation with an undergraduate degree was a great challenge in itself. And yet, I had been unfairly punishing myself for everything not working out exactly as I had hoped. Not only did I not fully deserve this “dream job” coming out of undergrad as a privileged kid with no real work experience, I also realize it wasn’t something I should ever have wished for in the first place. What I needed after graduation instead was a wake-up call to mature myself slowly and any opportunity to take my first baby steps in the professional world so that I could open my eyes to the “real” world outside of a college bubble. And thanks to God and all those who were kind enough to support me in my professional career since then, my experiences and journeys over the past ten years have done exactly that. They’ve shaped me into a person that no single job ever could, and I am very proud of the numerous growth opportunities I’ve had since then. Sometimes, God (or the Universe) refuses to hand you what you desperately want at that time, so that you can receive exactly what you need. Sometimes, it is your destiny to be molded into something completely different from what you always had in mind.

Refuse to judge yourself as a failure until your last day. Even if you feel like a failure now, you have plenty of time to prove yourself wrong in the next 10, 20 or 50 years. It’s never too late to come back from your setbacks. History books are filled with great heroes

that have come back from early setbacks in their lives: Thomas Edison, Albert Einstein, Abraham Lincoln, J.K. Rowling, Oprah, and Sylvester Stallone, just to name a few. Another helpful way to look at your life is to think of it as “playing the long game.” Don’t label yourself so hastily when you have such a long game left to play.

Another perspective tool I find useful is from one of my favorite authors and professors in South Korea named Kim Nan Do. The author has similarly visualized the length of a person’s life into a timeline on a 24-hour analog clock. It’s called the “Life Clock.” Based on your current age, what time would your Life Clock point to? The answer might surprise you. Visit <https://terryslifeclock.herokuapp.com/> to try it for free.

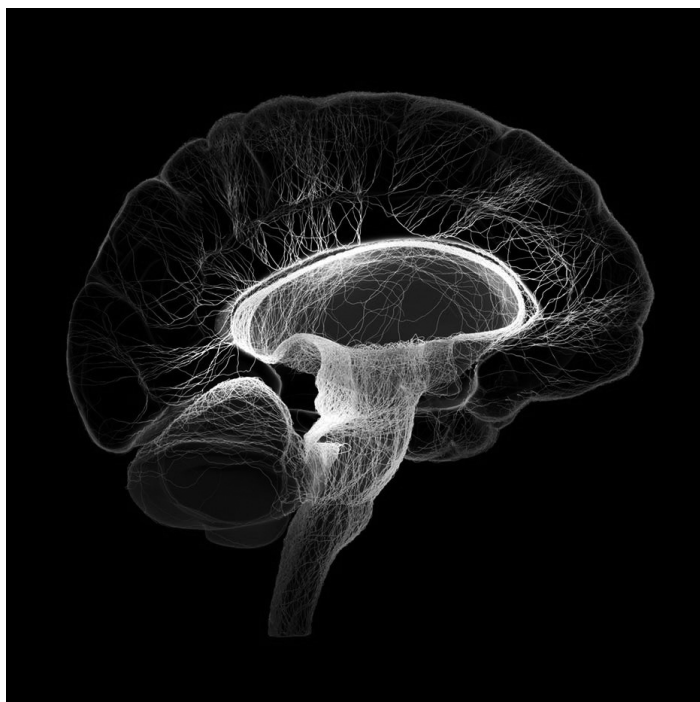


## II: What Creates Our Mind's Stories

In this section, we cover the myriad of factors that may be the origin of our mind's stories and obsessive rumination. We may need to dig deeper into the intersection of neuroscience, biology, psychology, cultural influences, childhood experiences and more.

## Chapter 7

# Our Brain (Part I)



The human brain is an incredible tool for performing all kinds of complex activities, such as planning for the future, remembering the past, playing a musical instrument, painting, dancing, catching a football in the touchdown zone and a million more. But human evolution seems to have failed in preparing us for when our brain starts malfunctioning from all this complexity, for example, in the

form of ruminating or obsessive thinking. Rumination may essentially be a disease of the overactive mind. In this case, our most advanced asset, the brain, is harming us instead of helping us in our daily lives.

Studies show that genes and family history are strong predictors of depression. Some of us may be born with a genetic predisposition that puts us at a higher risk for major depression later in life. There's a twofold to threefold increase in lifetime risk of developing major depression among first-degree relatives or anyone with a sibling or parent with depression.<sup>11</sup> I can attest to this through my own family history; not only did my sister and I experience major depression, but so did many relatives from both my mother's and father's side of the family. We cannot deny the significance of genetic "cards we are dealt" at birth when it comes to the risk of developing depression.

However, that doesn't mean that we should label depression as a result of some genetic defect or a random malfunctioning of the brain that we have no control over. My belief is that a large percentage of individuals who experience major depression or suicidal ideation in recent times are not born with a fundamental defect in their neurochemistry that causes depression with no apparent reason at all. Granted, this is difficult to prove because depression is another case of the "Nature versus Nurture," "Chicken or the egg" debate. How can we be sure if depression is resulting from the direct experiences of a person's life or from their fixed genetic destiny? Was the person's brain impacted by some external event that ended up causing depression or was the person innately born with the risk of developing depression? Although more con-

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11 Lohoff, Falk W. "Overview of the Genetics of Major Depressive Disorder." Current Psychiatry Reports, U.S. National Library of Medicine, 1 Dec. 2011, [www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC3077049/](http://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/pmc/articles/PMC3077049/).

clusive studies are needed, it may be safe to assume that there's a complex interdependence between genes and environment. There may be a specific subcategory of depression where genes play a part in making us more susceptible to depression, and then the actual experiences during a person's life may trigger that susceptibility, causing symptoms of major depression to surface as a result.

Then again, not all cases of depression or suicidal ideation may follow this pattern. Even if the surface-level symptoms are the same across two different patients of depression (such as a loss of interest in daily activities, a change in eating or sleeping patterns, fatigue, a lack of motivation, difficulty concentrating, etc.), a clear distinction has to be made between Patient A who may have recently suffered the loss of her entire family in a car accident, and Patient B who has no history of trauma or recent loss but instead has been suffering from years of obsessive rumination. It may not be far-fetched to say that a major portion of depression in recent times fits into this latter category. Some of us might have always carried the "dormant potential" for depression in our lives, and that potential may become awakened as a result of some stressful life event that we face. This is also why I believe that people who suffer from depression should not be judged as "weak" or "deficient." There may be a complicated mix of factors at play that may or may not trigger a person to fall into a depressed state that has nothing to do with the person's mental strength or fortitude. I think these reasons are what makes depression so confusing and difficult to understand or prevent. The actual trigger of depression for one group of people might be due to one similar set of reasons, but for some people, it might due to completely different, unrelated reasons.

For the subset of depression that I referred to as the “dormant potential” category, in which I include myself and Katie, it might be possible that some of us are naturally born with an abnormally high sensitivity to certain triggers that could lead to an overactivity of the brain. Some people simply knock this off as an “over-sensitive personality”; I personally compare this condition to allergies. Like a person whose physical immune system reacts hyper-sensitively to pollen or other allergens, a person born with a rumination-prone brain might be suffering from an over-sensitive mental reaction system that manifests itself in the form of obsessive, repetitive thoughts in response to stressful emotions, social situations or life events. And those stressful thought patterns may sound very much like the different examples we covered in the first section: self-loathing, regret, comparison, catastrophizing, self-judgment, labeling and more.

I would like to mention that I detest the commonly used “chemical imbalance in the brain” explanation of depression. Yes, there may be a neurochemical imbalance in people who are showing symptoms of depression, but the real question is, why did that imbalance arise in the first place? Because depending on the particular individual, the answer to that question may vary greatly even if the symptom cluster and affected neurotransmitter levels might look similar. And unless we answer that question of why, we will always end up treating the brain as a black box that we are unable to crack, while resorting to surface-level solutions that treat the symptoms alone.

Like we discussed before, the imbalance might have been caused by a laundry list of different reasons, perhaps something biological or over time by some other external factors. A doctor

saying that a person is depressed because of a chemical imbalance in the brain is almost like a car mechanic telling you that your car is broken because there is something wrong with the engine, and then not telling you anything else. Okay, can anybody tell us how and why the car engine ended up that way so that we can prevent the car from breaking down again, so that we are not at the complete mercy of this random disaster? If the answer is no, then it puts more responsibility back on us. We don't have to give up all our power and potential as individuals to try to understand what might have gone wrong with our own brains. And then we can work together to find the why instead of jumping at band-aid solutions.

Articles published by the Harvard Health Publishing of the Harvard Medical School seem to echo my sentiments that “the onset of depression is more complex than a brain chemical imbalance” and “[that] figure of speech doesn't capture how complex the disease is. Research suggests that rather, “there are many possible causes of depression, including faulty mood regulation by the brain, genetic vulnerability, stressful life events, medications, and medical problems. It's believed that several of these forces interact to bring on depression.”<sup>12</sup> So if depression turns out to be much more complex than just a biological complication, like many of us suspect, how can we do a better job of discovering the true causes behind the curtain? Is the existing system that heavily relies on medication going to help us discover the root causes of this issue, or are we just sweeping much bigger issues under the rug?

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<sup>12</sup> Harvard Health Publishing. “What Causes Depression?” Harvard Health, June 2009, <https://www.health.harvard.edu/mind-and-mood/what-causes-depression>.

I would like to emphasize that I do not claim to understand all the different subsets or variations of depression. I assume that this is a very specific type of depression that I've been focusing on throughout this book, the type that Katie and I experienced. For example, all the mindfulness tips or cognitive behavioral tips in the world may not be able to help a person who was born with a severe neurochemical imbalance that only medication can address or has experienced a physical trauma to the brain that's dramatically altered his physiology. Every individual's explanation for depression may be different in that way, and therefore, we cannot rely on a single, static answer for every episode of depression (although general patterns may exist depending on the cause).

That is why Dr. Daniel Amen, a renowned author of the book *Change Your Brain, Change Your Life*, talks about the importance of using visual neuroimaging techniques and brain scans to see and pinpoint what kind of electrical activity might be actually occurring inside a depressed person's brain instead of trying to guess their psychological condition through conversational evaluations. He makes the valid point that undiagnosed brain injuries or physiological issues inside the brain can lead to symptoms of mental illnesses, and using these visual means can help us rule out "biological" factors that might be causing psychological problems, and recognize general patterns within the brain. Generally speaking, any advanced technology that allows us to unravel the black box of the human brain by giving us additional qualitative or quantitative data points may help us significantly improve our understanding and diagnosis of depression.

All in all, I strongly disagree with the school of thought that it is some "faulty gene" that causes depression or the fault of some

weak character. Instead, the answer may be far more complicated. For example, studies indicate a possible correlation between high creativity (as well as IQ) and elevated risk for mood disorders and depression, hinting that the brain's capacity for depression and creativity may be linked.<sup>13</sup> This is not a surprising hypothesis, considering that some of the brilliant minds in history, such as Vincent Van Gogh, John Nash, Abraham Lincoln, Beethoven, Kafka and Freud, were presumed to have suffered from mental illnesses.

My belief (shared by many others) is that the same parts of the brain that cause excessive rumination are also closely linked to the areas responsible for creativity, memory, empathy, focus and problem-solving. And it may be up to us to channel our brain's focus toward the right direction so that we are able to use it for constructive creativity and empathy rather than self-destructive rumination. Yes, the downside of a depression-prone brain is a high sensitivity to stressful stimuli that can tip you into mental suffering. However, we can learn to embrace the sensitivities of our brain totally, and understand how to coexist with them.

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13 Carson, Shelley. "The Shared Vulnerability Model of Creativity and Psychopathology." *Creativity and Mental Illness*, Mar. 2011, pp. 253–280., doi:10.1017/cbo9781139128902.017.

## Chapter 8

# Our Brain (Part II)

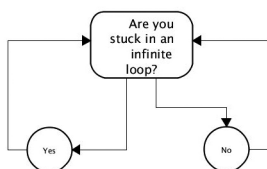
Researchers have coined the term “Default Mode Network” for the brain regions that becomes hyperactivated during “maladaptive rumination,” which is again the academic term for harmful, obsessive overthinking. The DMN is composed of cortical regions such as the cingulate, precuneus, inferior parietal cortex, medial prefrontal cortices, and the hippocampus.<sup>14</sup> In a state of activated DMN, you might appear to be “zoned out” or “spacing out,” when in fact you might be deeply in thought or ruminating over a certain topic. More specifically, the individual becomes heavily engaged in retrieving and labeling information, thinking about themselves and how they stack up in relation to others. Other activities include remembering the past and worrying about the future while also forming mental narratives around all these topics. As you are overworking your brain’s DMN to run through all these stories in your mind, you may also be reliving all kinds of emotions related to those stories and releasing the stress hormone cortisol in reaction to these thoughts.

It’s still difficult to pinpoint why people suffer from obsessive thinking and rumination, although our brain’s neural activity obviously plays a big part in it. In an ideal world, we could take a clinically depressed person and tell them, “Hey, stop dwelling on your mind’s stories! Snap out of it!” But as you may already know, that’s

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<sup>14</sup> Buckner, R. L., Jessica R. Andrews-Hanna, and Daniel L. Schacter. (2008). “The brain’s default network.” *Annals of the New York Academy of Sciences*, 1124 (1): 1–38. doi:10.1196/annals.1440.011.

one of the most useless things you could tell somebody suffering from severe depression. Our neural activity is far more complicated and less in direct conscious control of the suffering person. It is as though the brain is stuck on a certain subconscious pattern and causing repeated pain inside your mind. An out-of-control mental process is running in your mind constantly, causing distressing thoughts and feelings over and over again, taking up large amounts of your brain's energy and leading to prolonged stress. And the problem is, it doesn't seem to have an end in sight.



Rumination of the brain may be similar to a computer systems process—a software bug caused by an infinite loop without a proper termination or end condition. This results in a completely frozen, unresponsive program or a system crash

Most mental processes—if they are simple and straightforward—usually have a beginning and an end. If you are thinking about what you need to do at work tomorrow, it usually ends once you run out of tasks you need to complete or after you actually write them down. If you are remembering the list of Netflix videos you watched yesterday, that process ends quickly enough because there's usually only a limited number of videos you could fit into one day. If you are cleaning up your room, that comes to an end after everything is clean; your mind knows the end destination and feels great when everything has been cleaned up. Same with a

100-meter race; you know where you start and where you need to end, and after you finish the race, you feel accomplished.

But what if your mind couldn't tell when a mental activity needs to end, because it was completely overwhelmed by the intensity of the experience? For instance, imagine you had a particularly angry interaction with a frustrating coworker at work or a bully at school. Maybe they physically shoved you or called you insulting names during a public occasion. Remembering that experience now might make you feel angry just like you did back then and in turn recall that anger from the past into the present moment, especially if you weren't able to resolve that emotion appropriately in the past. If the event was distressing enough, it can keep you stuck in that past moment through this unresolved anger, like an open wound that never closed up or a race that your mind thinks has never ended. So instead, the angry memory keeps replaying through your mind, because the brain is still trying to "completely process" what happened but keeps failing to reach the finish line. It's almost as though the mind tries desperately to "think its way" out of the powerful feelings left behind by the experience. But it keeps failing. So it tries again and again, while sucking up all your available mental energy during the process and causing your mind to become stuck and unresponsive, like a frozen computer program.

This kind of mental pattern may exist because our brain is designed by evolution to be hypersensitive and hypervigilant of negative emotions such as fear, anger, shame, embarrassment and others. According to theories in evolutionary biology, the genetic expression of a brain that makes sure you are aware of potential dangers in your environment was better for the survival of our ancestors, and that gene has survived and been passed down to us.

For example, the memory of a wild lion who almost killed you in the jungle is something that may cause extreme fear and stress in your brain, and something you must definitely remember if you don't want to face the same situation again. So your brain is designed to keep that kind of stressful memory extra vivid in the foreground so that it may better inform your future decisions. This inherited function of our brain may have kept us alive in those early eras of human evolution. Basically, it might be our brain saying, "that was an incredibly scary, fearful, angry or shameful event. Therefore, be super aware of this event, and remember it as much as possible. Try to prevent it from happening again."

However, this is also why our brain might be at risk of going off-course. Imagine our brain keeps pulling up that horrible memory of the wild lion over the next several weeks, months and even years without your conscious permission. That may be similar to what may be happening to us when we ruminate. That same hypervigilant capability of the brain keeps bringing us back to past experiences that cause us fear, anger, shame and more. Your mind keeps bringing it back to the foreground of your attention, your main browser window so to speak, and because it's an angry and painful memory, you become furious yet again in the present moment. And then your brain keeps doing this minutes later... and then again ... and again and again. Like a hamster wheel, on and on goes this infinite loop of mental distress.

I don't claim to have one perfect solution to rumination although there's various discoveries and ideas we cover in the later chapters. The reason I understand them at this level is because I have myself experienced these kinds of painful mental loops over and over again in my life. Katie's diary entries also show time and

time again, almost on a daily basis, that she engaged in the same kind of repetitive thought patterns around self-hatred, regret, social anxiety and despair without an end in sight. Personally, the types of therapy that have worked best for controlling my rumination are cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) and hypnotherapy. Engaging in mental exercises and techniques such as journaling, visualization, anchoring and meditative breathing can help close your mental loops and unresolved emotions. With enough time, effort and/or the help of a trained therapist, I've seen first-hand that we can resolve these emotional conflicts that may be at the root of our mind's obsessive stories. In the third section of this book, we go deeper into how we can address harmful mental habits and improve our ability to take control of our mind's stories.

## Chapter 9

# Culture

In April 2019, it was reported that about 20 Indian students from Telangana committed suicide after receiving low scores on their national board exams.<sup>15</sup> A particular student named Sirisha who had failed her biology test set herself on fire after her parents left for work. After the suicides, it was revealed that the bad scores had resulted from an error in the examination scoring software used by the testing companies. It was a complete tragedy. Those students must have felt emotionally devastated after receiving their exam scores and generalized that they were “failures” in life, when in fact nothing could have been further from the truth. It was yet another tragedy that reminded me of Katie’s incident.

Such stories of suicide have become more and more common in competition-driven Asian countries where your academic performance in your teens is considered extremely critical to getting into the right colleges and subsequently the right jobs that guarantee you “success for life.” No wonder then that those exam scores must have literally seemed like a “life-or-death” situation to those students. Only an outsider who has no prior exposure to Asian culture and its value system can objectively detect their irrational perceptions of the situation. How could an exam score created by a faulty scoring software lead these kids to throw away their lives?

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15 Nagaraja, Gali. (2019, April 25). “19 Telangana students commit suicide in a week after ‘goof-ups’ in intermediate exam results; parents blame software firm.” Firstpost, [www.firstpost.com/india/19-telangana-students-commit-suicide-in-a-week-after-goof-ups-in-intermediate-exam-results-parents-blame-software-firm-6518571.html](http://www.firstpost.com/india/19-telangana-students-commit-suicide-in-a-week-after-goof-ups-in-intermediate-exam-results-parents-blame-software-firm-6518571.html).

Who's responsible for these children believing in these lies? We may not be able to point fingers at just one person in this case. I attribute this to culture.

South Korea is another example of a country whose culture may be negatively impacting the mental health of its people, especially due to the recent growth of its economy over the last 50 years. An alarming number of celebrities, politicians and other public figures have been reported to have suffered from depression and committed suicide in the last few decades. "There's a very clear societal pressure on South Koreans, especially young adults, based around a really high, unidimensional focus on one definition of success," says Dr. Chad Ebesutani, a U.S.-licensed psychologist at the Seoul Counseling Center, a counseling service in Seoul's Gangnam district aimed at expats.<sup>16</sup>

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16 Watkins, James & Ebesutani, Chad. (2018, February 9). "South Korea's mental health problem — that Koreans don't admit." OZY. Retrieved from <https://www.ozy.com/acumen/south-koreas-mental-health-problem-that-koreans-dont-admit/83629>.



A list of Korean celebrities, actors, musicians and TV stars who's recently committed or attempted suicide after suffering from depression: Jong Hyun from K-pop group Shinee, Goo Hara from girl group Kara, actress Choi Jin Sil, actor Park Yong-ha and more.

It is widely agreed by the South Koreans that these issues may be stemming from its success-driven culture where people constantly compete for and obsess over superior status. Young adults are pitted against each other to fight for the best schools, jobs and opportunities that only exist at the narrow top of the pyramid. They are pushed by their families, peers and the media to achieve this skewed, distorted vision of “success,” which is so horribly ill-defined and only available to the elite few. The general public sentiment says, “The standard of success is X. You are at Y. You must do whatever you can to achieve X, otherwise you are not good enough.” This kind of mindset is not sustainable for a society as a whole and sets it up for failure because of the unrealistically high bar set for happiness.

Whether it's India, Korea, Japan, the U.S. or anywhere else in

the world, we are significantly impacted by the culture that we live in and its mainstream values. The shared beliefs and value system of the community that surrounds us bombard us every second of every day through movies, television shows, advertisements, social media (particularly Instagram), conversations, newspapers, magazines, billboards and much more. You are subconsciously absorbing all sorts of ideas and standards about what's attractive, what's important, what's cool and what's "right" or "wrong" through these channels. And if the culture of the community you live in focuses on defining life success as a "job that's only available for the elite few," and that job cannot be obtained if you do not have an impressive report card, then you can imagine why young kids in their teens would feel distraught about doing badly on school exams. It might have literally felt like "life and death" for them.

It's crucial for us to be aware of the huge impact that our culture can have on our mindset. Otherwise, our minds are left vulnerable against the powerful, persuasive influences of mainstream messaging from TV, social media, advertising, movies and other channels. Nobody can say one culture is superior to another but when it comes to the subject of depression and suicide, there's been clear statistics that show certain countries have extremely low rates of suicide compared to other populations. Countries like Barbados, Bahamas, Jamaica, Maldives, Pakistan, Morocco and Phillippines show the lowest suicide rates while Lithuania, Guayana, South Korea, Suriname and Japan rank as some of the highest, according to the World Population Review in 2019.

Challenging your own culture—let alone challenging everything you have learned over the course of your childhood from

parents and schools—is no easy task at any point in your life. It's much easier to sit back, relax and let others do our thinking for us. But in times of crisis and rising rates of depression, it becomes important for us to recognize what's working for us and what's not. For instance, we can take the Asian-American demographic as a clear example of how culture enforces the standards of success among its people.

In the last several decades, Asian-Americans have grown up with the stereotypical idea that the key to a successful life is to get admitted into Ivy League universities and then become doctors, lawyers or engineers. "Make the most money, get the most prestigious job, buy the nicest car, and marry the best partner. And that's success." That's what we were repeatedly told by our parents, culture and community every day. But is that really sound life advice for future generations? This traditional definition of success focuses all our attention on solely achieving a position of wealth, social status and recognition without first building the foundation necessary to become a person of value. It fails to value qualities such as integrity, altruism, service or patience. It also places an undue amount of academic and professional pressure on young adults who often fall into the trap of becoming short-sighted, cut-throat machines obsessively concerned with competition and achievement.

I'm not claiming that the typical Asian parents' definition of success is entirely wrong. Professions like doctors, lawyers and engineers are highly essential in modern society and deserve respect based on their long years of education and beneficial impact on the communities around them. And of course making a stable salary is better than being poor or homeless. It's almost impossible to live a comfortable, independent adult life in modern countries without a good income. What I am talking about here is encour-

aging the future generations to pursue those professions for the right reasons and not just for achieving an image of great success in the eyes of others. Also, we must suggest alternative questions and options to them. What about the courage to follow and actualize your most creative ideas? What about the willingness to improve the status quo for the suffering people in our society? What about fighting for the greater good of the community and protecting the global environment? Somehow, those important values have become secondary to ambitious young people in many cultures, completely eclipsed by the allure of money, impressive job titles and high social status.

Modern thought leaders including Daniel Pink, Simon Sinek and Dr. Raj Raghunathan of the book, *If You're So Smart, Why Aren't You Happy?*, have discussed in depth the true ingredients to career satisfaction and lasting happiness in their books and interviews, which I would like to mention here. Once a person's basic needs are satisfied, the ingredients to lasting career happiness consistently include the following elements, which are vastly different from the traditional concepts of material success we discussed above:

1. Having meaningful social relationships.
2. Being proficient and skilled at your craft.
3. Having the freedom to make your own decisions independently.
4. Having an empowering purpose that drives and inspires you.
5. Knowing that you are making a positive impact on the lives of others.

Challenging the established ideas of our culture is never easy because it's so ingrained in our daily lives. You must literally tear yourself away from years of social conditioning internalized as a child in order to adapt to or create a new set of rules. You must make trade-off decisions all the time. As for me, I am constantly debating whether a situation requires that I act according to my traditional Asian values or according to the rules of the multicultural American environment I find myself in. It's a common occurrence for Asian-Americans and second-generation immigrants in general. No wonder it's easier to let other people do the thinking sometimes; it gets so darn complicated and confusing. But just because it is difficult doesn't mean we should stop trying. Sometimes, it pays to be the "outlier" or "lone wolf" in your group, especially if you suspect there's something unhealthy about the established set of shared beliefs among the majority of people around you.

Another way that culture impacts us is in the way we view ourselves. Asian-Americans and other minority groups could complain all day about the racial discrimination that we face in this country, although complaining alone isn't going to change anything. Examples include people throwing racial insults at us in public, criticizing our physical features, stereotyping Asian men as lacking masculine qualities or stereotyping Asian women as exotic mistresses. The list is really endless, and the lack of our representation in the media certainly doesn't help this cause, especially when it comes to children who grow up with a severe lack of Asian-American role models who look like them.

There's no easy solution to changing this kind of public perception. But regardless of what we hear and see in the media, we must

stay committed to always creating healthy stories about ourselves in our minds. You must stand firm and stay true to what makes you unique, attractive and valuable, no matter what others, including the mainstream media, try to say otherwise. So remember to be aware of what the culture around you—whether it's that of your country, the company you work for or the ethnic group you are part of—can do to your own mind's stories. Oftentimes, the agenda of the “culture creators” and “culture drivers” at the top of the pyramid has nothing to do with us, and they couldn't care less about the mental well-being of specific individuals like you and me. Nevertheless, nobody can stop us from having healthy images of ourselves in our own minds.

As a closing note, I do want to highlight the positive parts of Asian culture that I have not mentioned so far. Although I've pointed out how certain aspects of modernized Asian countries are negatively impacting the mental health of the younger generations, I don't want you to conclude that Asian cultures are faulty or flawed in general. As a South Korean-born person myself who immigrated to the U.S. as a teenager, I retain a strong appreciation for the richness and depth of different Asian cultures as well as their individual history and philosophy. Confucianism and Buddhism both play a big role in how East-Asian cultures have become the way they are today with shared values like filial piety, deference to authority, group harmony, self-sacrifice and more. It's certainly difficult to tell if it's “Old Asia” or “New Asia” that's contributing to the depression epidemic although it may be due to a little bit of both. If I were to make a guess, it may be possible that the people in South Korea are conflicted because their old philosophy is telling them to obey and follow authority figures without questioning, while the new Korea is slowly realizing that many of

those authority figures might have been imperfect or leading them astray. Regardless, we need to hold on to what's beneficial and positive about our culture that we must continue to appreciate and follow, and on the other hand, identity and change what's holding us back.

## Chapter 10

# People Around You

The way you talk to yourself and the stories you tell yourself are significantly impacted by the people you interact with daily. For example, if you are around other people who constantly criticize you or tell you negative, angry or harmful things every day, your brain cannot help but absorb that negativity. On the contrary, if you are around happy, energetic and inspiring people who encourage you, you cannot help but become happier, more energetic and inspired yourself. That is why the motivational speaker Jim Rohn once said, “We are the average of the five people we spend the most time with.” It is almost impossible not to be influenced by the moods, words and actions of the people around you.

The impact of “culture” that we discussed in the last chapter is like that of an orchestra conductor. Culture may set the main theme for our stories and the foundation from where our thoughts and values originate. And the actual people you see and hear on a frequent basis at home, school, work, and on Instagram, are like the rest of the orchestra ensemble, the musicians who follow the conductor’s lead and play the music. The everyday people, including ourselves, are the perpetrators and messengers of the culture that influences us. We see our friends in school, and they talk to us about the latest Instagram pic that a famous celebrity posted last night, or perhaps the latest episode of *The Bachelor*. We see our co-workers in the office, and talk with each other about Jessie’s latest promotion or the latest political news on TV.

It's important to be aware of how different our daily conversations become depending on the group of people that we spend time with. Some people like to talk only about themselves or their upcoming summer trip to Paris. Some like to talk about their latest passion project or the latest gossip. Some people just like one-upping all your stories and making you feel less than you are. And if you think about these conversations from the perspective of protecting yourself from depression and rumination, distinguishing those conversations that might help your mind's stories from those that are completely unhelpful and downright dangerous is crucial. You must choose to be around positive, uplifting and stable people if you want to create healthy stories in your own mind. Through a kind of emotional contagion, your brain can benefit from other people's uplifting, positive words and stories which can be healing for your own mind.

These effects are also very similar on social media, especially Instagram. If you follow a group of friends who seem to post pictures all the time, whether it's showing off their latest trip abroad or the awesome party they went to, you often cannot help but see their posts and feel envious. By choosing to follow them on social media, we are choosing to be open to another person's influence, positive or not. Remember, Instagram is full of status-obsessed and secretly insecure people who post filtered, choreographed and Photoshopped pictures of their lives that make it look like they are having a better time than they actually are. It's mostly a facade. So you must notice that, instead of being influenced by all kinds of enticing pictures, and then suffering from FOMO. You've probably heard this all before but social media can take a huge toll on your mind because it fuels your status obsession, comparison-based mindset and envy. These perfectly filtered pictures are

literally being shoved into your face 24/7 through your mobile device (even with push notifications so you never miss a single post). Social media is sometimes even more harmful than corporate advertising; it doesn't just affect people's tastes but also their constant sense of well-being. We constantly get reminded to ask ourselves, "Wow, this person looks like she is doing so well. How am I doing?"

I'm not saying that social media doesn't have a useful purpose. I personally enjoy being active on social media and interacting with people from all over the world. Social media has definitely helped us become closer but this "closeness" must be managed just like in any other relationship. Being open all day to influences from others is not always helpful for your psyche, especially if you are following the wrong crowd. So it's important to open yourself up to the helpful influences and avoid the unhelpful ones, although recognizing which ones are which is easier said than done. There's definitely helpful and inspiring YouTube and Instagram accounts out there that post educational content, mindfulness tips, useful news and more. A good tip is to try to separate the people who post content for their own selfish motives, from those who might have more genuine, unselfish motives in mind. The types of people you might want to follow are the following:

- Looking for genuine connections and conversations
- Sharing their creative works and looking for feedback
- Posting educational or inspiring content

Lastly, I want to touch on the effects of isolation. Because depression can be a very isolating experience, having a loyal group

of supportive people in your life is integral to preventing depression and also to climbing out of a depressive state. It's difficult to determine whether depression causes isolation, or isolation causes depression, but there is strong evidence that those two are highly correlated. Extended isolation might cause you to resort to self-soothing techniques like binge-eating and other escapist behaviors that offer immediate gratification but are destructive over the long run and push you into a deeper depressive state. Researchers have discovered that social activities lead the brain to release a feel-good hormone called oxytocin, which effectively cancels out and reverse the effects of stress while keeping depression at bay. Small physical actions like hugging, touching, or even being next to each other have been known to increase oxytocin as well. Having a pet has proven to be amazingly therapeutic for similar reasons.

The irony in Katie's case was that she dearly loved her friends and family and truly treasured her bonds with other people, but when she fell into a deep depression, she seemed to be unable to be vulnerable around those same friends. Instead she chose to tackle her inner demons all on her own. It was like she was "too independent" for her own good. Knowing Katie, she might have believed that divulging her inner demons to her friends would have made her seem "weak" or "unlovable," which would have been in conflict with her perfectionist ways. It is true that when you reveal your innermost struggles to others, you risk the discomfort and pain of them judging you. However, there will also be others who are kind and understanding of your pain and can help you heal. In my personal bouts with depression, the friends I appreciated the most were those who were the least judgmental and treated my condition as a temporary crisis that I would eventually fight my way out of. They would spend time talking to me and offering me

words of encouragement when I was struggling the most. I have no doubt that such positive peer influence and social support were a major part of what saved me from my depression.

## Chapter 11

# Childhood Conditioning

The way your mind operates is largely conditioned by your past experiences as a child, when your brain was the most susceptible to influence and soaking up ideas like a sponge. A habit you developed at 7 years-old can stay with you even at 30 years-old. Having a near-death experience in a swimming pool when you are a kid can traumatize you for life and make you avoid water as a full-grown adult. That's why looking back at the influences you received from your parents (and other authority figures in your childhood environment) may be crucial to understanding your current mentality. They impacted your brain and your mind's stories in a major way through childhood conditioning.

For example, in Asian cultures, filial piety or being respectful and obedient towards elders is the main virtue that parents teach their children. Not that there's anything inherently wrong with filial piety, but the darker side of this cultural norm comes to the fore when the elders start abusing their power to shame children into "proper" conduct. Pressure, punishment and guilt trips are the emotional tools often used by Asian parents to sculpt high-performing, over-achieving sons and daughters. Their lessons usually go along the lines of "Bring honor to your family through obedience and excellence. If you fail, you will bring dishonor. If you disobey, you will be punished. Succeeding is the only way to make us happy." We are not talking treats for getting an A+ on an exam; it's physical punishment over scoring anything less than an A or

being grounded for months if you get caught hanging out with your boyfriend instead of studying.

Back in the 90s, I remember being in some after-school program in Seoul where a Korean teacher in her early 30s literally beat my hands with the hard end of a wooden broom to discipline me whenever I incorrectly answered my math problems. Although hitting students is no longer allowed in South Korea, that's just one example of an Asian culture that expects children to fear rules and elders to ingrain blind obedience toward authority in children. "You answered this algebra problem wrong? How could you be so stupid? Here's some pain to make sure you don't get it wrong again. I'm hitting you for your own good." How thoughtful.

I never questioned such Asian values growing up because I had internalized them as the "normal way" of living. Until my 20s, I seldom challenged my elders or parents because I thought that obeying them and making them happy were always the "right" thing to do. Now that I've spent the last 20 years in the U.S., I feel very differently about those beliefs. It's up to us to apply our learned thought patterns to situations only if they are relevant, and then discard them when they are not. It took me a very long time to break out of that traditional mold and to be able to look at my elders and parents objectively. You need to determine who and what they are, and especially, what their limitations are.

I'm not saying that you should always disobey your parents and elders either. Of course there's several situations where it's best to follow their advice. However, sooner or later, you must learn how to do your own thinking. And when you do become a mature adult capable of making your own decisions, your parents who've raised you and led your decisions when you were a child are no

longer the right people to continue forcing you in a certain direction. Like a pair of children's shoes that no longer fit you because you've outgrown them, the childhood conditioning and rules set by your parents when you were just a kid need to be discarded as well. If our goal is to live a satisfying life as mature adults capable of making our own decisions, we cannot allow our parents or elders to order us around without questioning them—especially when the rules they have been asking you to blindly obey are based on their own personal limitations, biases and the imperfect childhood conditioning they inherited themselves. Then we would just be repeating the cycle. Somebody has to notice such cycles and stop them from repeating.

The irony is that parents will continue to try to tell you what to do and how to live your life because they will always see their little baby when they look at you, often in the genuine belief that they know better than you. Your job as an independent adult is to filter their advice. The helpful advice stay. Ignore the rest. And it's up to you to decide which is which. No more blind obedience or listening to them more than you listen to yourself. Look at them objectively. Is there a chance that their advice and comments are coming from their own inherited ideas of what's right and wrong?

Another example of what Asian cultures need to address is our story about how success is limited to a few prestigious professions based on social status and money. That is essentially a story fabricated by the previous generations and relayed to us through our parents and grandparents. And it's completely understandable. The very first generations of Asian immigrants had almost zero career options in America and other countries abroad, except for manual labor or businesses like restaurants, laundromats and nail

salons. Of course they wanted better lives for their children, and we cannot blame them for that. A life of stable income with a respected job title and high level of education is very different compared to a painful life of poverty with a job where nobody treats you with respect. Many of my Korean uncles and aunts suffered through that lower-class life and made sure to remind me often to learn from their hardship and study hard.

But the world is changing faster today than ever before. There are new occupations now that have more responsibility and future potential than the traditional paths that were held sacred before. There's entrepreneurs, artists and innovators who are creating extraordinary value for the people around them while being completely unbound by a job title. In this age of rapid change and innovation, the best blueprint for success may not be the one that was fixed 50 years ago by our parents and grandparents. We are the ones who must adapt to and steer the world. We have to change it, so we can make it better than the world in which our parents lived before, not succeed solely based on their old rules.

I'm not advocating that you quit med school, law school, graduate program or whatever career path you are actively involved in. If it's a path that motivates you to live a purpose-driven life, then by all means, go study what inspires you and throw yourself 100% into your profession. I am advocating however that the decision to choose your life path come from you, and you only. And if that decision turns out to be a bad fit for you, then you have every right and responsibility to change your course at any point in your life. Granted, you must give enough time to a chosen career path before you make a major switch; otherwise you will be wasting time

and money jumping back and forth between different paths, never deciding on anything in particular. But limiting yourself to a few career choices, just because of your parents' wishes, is completely illogical. You must choose for yourself and find out for yourself what is best for you.

I do want to emphasize one thing: Our parents are not the problem. That's not what I'm trying to say. I owe so much to both my parents. My mother is a strong single mother who raised my sister and me as the sole breadwinner of the family in a foreign country. We do have to recognize that our parents are not perfect, but we must still love, forgive and respect them. They did their best with whatever they knew and had at the time. Challenging the mindset of our community and developing a healthy mindset has less to do with disobeying our parents and more to do with identifying and fighting for what's best for everyone. Be aware that faulty stories can seep into your mind through your childhood influences from your parents and family members, but do not blame them needlessly. Now that we recognize those influences as adults, it's time to let go of past issues and move toward a better direction together.

If you are currently a college or high school student who's grown up with the traditional Asian mindset and are afraid of challenging your parents, I urge you to start learning how to think for yourself. It doesn't mean disobey your parents every chance you get, but it does mean you start developing your own internal compass for how you want to navigate your own life. At the end of the day, if you let anybody else including your parents dictate your life, the one who will suffer the most, if they turn out to be wrong, is you. If you do not start this process of thinking for yourself early

on, then you may end up as a full-grown adult who's completely directionless while still toiling away in the same hamster wheel set up by your parents who may no longer be alive. By taking control of your own life decisions, you can start learning today how to be more responsible. It's scary but liberating at the same time. If you are wrong, it's on you. And if you are right, that's on you as well.

Rather than just blindly assuming that your parents are the best equipped to make your career decisions, start by choosing your own major and classes. Rely on mentors and peers around you to gather the most accurate information; I even encourage you to find different mentors for different reasons. For example, find a mentor you can rely on for career advice, and then find another mentor for relationship advice. The possibilities are endless if you keep your eyes open. Base your decisions on facts, latest information and your personal strengths and then be ready to experiment and change course if something doesn't feel like the right fit. When it comes to choosing a career path, research what kind of topics you are naturally curious about learning, what kind of problems you are naturally good at solving, what kind of mentors you would like to learn from and what kind of projects inspire you.

Don't be discouraged because you can't seem to figure out everything on your own right away. You are not supposed to. Take your time, learn from trial and error and experiment again and again while asking for mentorship from others. You will get to where you want to be in small steps. Trust the process and work patiently on figuring out your unique self-potential.



(Above is a venn diagram of a model to find your career “happy place.” It highlights the intersection of the three overlapping circles: the problems and needs of the world, things that inspire and empower you (i.e., your passions and inspirations), and your skill sets (i.e. your personal talents). This was created by Scott McGregor, one of my professional mentors from Cisco Systems in North Carolina)

I also don’t recommend you blindly follow the “follow your passion” advice, which is often misunderstood by people who think that following their passion allows them to do whatever they want without thinking about the consequences, like impulsively setting up a dessert shop in a town that’s already saturated with dessert options, or trying to make a living as an exotic dancer in a town that could care less about exotic dancing. You wanting to do what makes you happy is important, but you must be willing to put in the effort necessary to ensure that you are providing something valuable to the people around you and endure the consequences when things don’t turn out to be as rosy as you initially imagined. In business terms, you must achieve the right “product-market fit” with the world around you. Whatever service, product or value you want to offer to the world to make an impact, you must gauge its potential by how well you will be able to serve the people in that community as well as how much demand it will generate.

A better advice in my opinion may be “follow your passion responsibly under a few conditions.” We might want to encourage the next generation to follow their passions and pursue what they are inspired by as long as (and this caveat is crucial) they also satisfy certain criteria similar to below:

1. Stand on your own two feet while following your passion. Don't completely rely on other people, such as your parents, to carry your financial burden during the pursuit of your dreams.
2. Be mature enough to persevere for years to make your dream come true and accept failure when it doesn't.
3. Make sure that the success of your passion actually results in providing concrete value to the community around you.

Lastly, I want to mention that a degree from an Ivy League university is not always synonymous with lifelong success, like Asian parents often believe. In fact, in his book *David and Goliath*, Malcolm Gladwell specifically mentions the dangers of the “small fish in a big pond” scenario where being in an environment full of people seemingly more accomplished than yourself can actually make you less motivated to try your best due to relative deprivation and feelings of inferiority. We have more than enough examples in history where a person from humble origins ended up becoming the best, most highly regarded leader of his or her respective discipline, even though they didn't have the most prestigious academic background (Abraham Lincoln, Thomas Edison, Albert Einstein and Steve Jobs come to mind). The typical Asian parents' focus on an Ivy League education is overhyped and dis-

proportionate compared to their lack of focus in teaching children how to think independently and outside the box—the very qualities that are essential for future leadership, creativity and imagination. And it was Albert Einstein who said, “the true sign of intelligence is not knowledge but imagination.”

## Chapter 12

# Your Self-Identity

As we discussed in the first section, our mind is always coming up with stories about what we are and how we are in relation to others. It's like our mind is trying to come up with its own identity by comparing itself to others. Psychologists have coined the term "ego" to describe this type of thinking and the part of your mind that's always trying to come up with an opinion of the self as separate from other people. We also call this your "sense of self" or "self-identity."

One of the most difficult things about managing your ego is how to balance it. When your sense of self is too weak, you can be unsure of yourself, easily swayed by other people's opinions and suffer from low self-esteem. On the other hand, if your sense of self is too strong, you might come across as an over-aggressive, arrogant narcissist who cares only about yourself and proving how better you are than everybody else. Realizing the big part that your ego plays in your inner peace and learning to be comfortable in your own skin are important life-long pursuits that require great introspection and conscious effort over time.

An example of how self-identity may play a role in depression is seen in the way many Asian-Americans struggle with their identity. They are often brought up with the traditional Asian mindset and then face a completely new culture in American schools and workplaces where they have to adapt and learn how to fit in with other Americans. I've seen my share of self-hating Asian-Amer-

icans who are not at all happy with who they are; although they desperately want to fit into the mainstream culture of predominantly white communities, they have a hard time balancing their ethnic background with this desire to conform. Oftentimes, they strive to make themselves more “generic,” hoping this would make it easier for others to relate to them and not find them “weird” or “too Asian.” Some Asian-Americans associate being Asian with a sense of shame instead of pride or self-love. I guess that’s understandable considering the lack of positive, accurate Asian-American representation in the media and some lingering racism in this country. I can’t help but feel sad about that.

All in all, what’s most important is that you love yourself unconditionally. I consider the slight South Korean accent in my English with a sense of pride because it reminds me of where I came from and everything that my family’s been through. When people poke fun at me because I cannot pronounce a difficult English word perfectly, I laugh it off and move on with my day. Your multi-ethnic identity and experiences as a first-generation or second-generation immigrant from another country are great assets, not liabilities in today’s global world. Take pride in your identity, background and ethnicity. To fit into a mainstream society, it’s not always wise to flaunt how different you are from others, but it’s also unfair on yourself to deny who you are inside. Ultimately, it’s a choice as to how you will identify yourself, but I hope you choose the option to love every part of yourself.

At the same time, I also think it’s important to take pride in your own individuality completely separate from your race. At the risk of sounding like a quote from *Fight Club*, you are not just your ethnicity, skin color, job title, degree, the university you graduated from, the salary you earn, the money you have or the number of

Instagram followers you have. You are all of those things but also none of those things. Even without possessions, status, titles, labels or skills, you are a valuable human being that doesn't need any of those things to thrive in this world with all your limitless potential.

I don't claim to be an expert on ego psychology but there's others who are. Eckhart Tolle articulates how important it is to be aware of how you identify yourself and also how your own mind likes to attach itself to labels and titles in order to create its own stories. We have a tendency to attach our identities to our possessions, the titles that make us sound important and the groups that we belong to. It's very common to see egotistical people brag about how much money they have, which expensive car they drive, which impressive job title they have, or which exclusive club they are a part of. You must learn to recognize those tendencies in others and also in yourself so that you can prevent your own obsessive ego from running out of control. I pray that someday we all achieve a level of inner peace that allows us to be completely at peace with ourselves, so that we can appreciate each other without having to argue about who's more special.



# III: Taking Control of Our Mind's Stories

This last section consists of different ideas and strategies we can use on a daily basis to address the rumination we've discussed in this book. What are the actual techniques we can use to deal with harmful, repetitive stories in our minds? How can we as a society better address depression? What are we truly missing here?

## Chapter 13

# The Current State of Depression Treatment and Understanding

When it comes to accurately defining the causes of major depression, many questions still remain unanswered today. While researching this topic, I had the chance to interview Dr. Chad Ebesutani, a leading clinical psychologist with a Ph.D. from UCLA and founder and director of the Seoul Counseling Center in South Korea. Following are excerpts from our conversation.

Dr. Ebesutani: “If I were to grade the current level of mental health treatment for depression in the world, I would give it a C. We have figured some things out, but definitely in need of improvement. I’m not satisfied with the current state of things at all. There’s so much we can do and I know we can do more. I don’t want to blame psychologists—as I understand the challenge of treating complex things—but we have yet to really understand what works [for depression] and how to communicate what works to others.

At the end of the day, I believe that effectively treating depression involves starting with looking at what the individual can do first. In this way, everyone can be part of the solution. Otherwise, it really is a downward spiral—you start feeling down, you don’t do anything, you feel even more down so you don’t meet anybody. It’s hard to pick yourself up after that [spiral].”

Dr. Ebesutani states that depression is a multifaceted problem

that often cannot be addressed by medication alone, but needs more of an integrated, comprehensive approach. He also sees the need to integrate “cognitive behavior psychotherapy” (which is more of a science and technique-oriented) with the warmer and more emotionally-oriented “client-centered” approaches.

Dr. Ebesutani’s opinions rang true to my own experiences as well. Most people did not challenge the over-simplistic explanation from Katie’s psychiatrist that he wasn’t exactly sure what had led to Katie’s suicidal depression. After all, Katie had been going through weekly therapy sessions and prescribed antidepressant medication by the clinic. When I started experiencing depression myself in college and showed up at the university health clinic in desperation, I also got a sense of what Katie might have experienced. I felt like a nameless object in a factory queue that just needed another quick-and-easy fix so that I could make room for the next person in line. I waited my turn in a quiet lobby with other grim-looking students and then received a 45-minute conversational evaluation in a private room where I was told to talk about my biggest problems to a complete stranger who told me she was a social worker. After I was done trying to poorly articulate my internal struggles and rumination to this person in 45 minutes, she simply told me that I should be prescribed SSRI medication and come back next week if things don’t improve by then. To be honest, it was an incredibly discouraging and disappointing experience.

Fast-forward to today, we still have yet to see any noticeable paradigm shifts for diagnosing or curing depression. One of the reasons I wrote this book is to bring more awareness to the fact that things are clearly not working very well with the status quo. If the current system of psychiatry and psychotherapy were

enough to handle this global, multifaceted problem, we wouldn't be seeing the continuing rise of depression and suicide rates today. I am not saying that we should discontinue trusting in psychiatrists altogether; we can all benefit immensely from their expertise and experience. To be honest, they all have an incredibly tough job. When you compare psychology to "observable" sciences like chemistry, biology or physics, we must remember that we still have no reliable way to see into the "black box" of the brain and deduce which thought patterns are exactly leading to which neural activity. No objective tests or measurable metrics are currently available for doctors to deterministically "test" for depression, like we can test blood samples, urine samples or heart rate for detecting various diseases. This may be one of the biggest reasons psychology continues to rely on subjective patient feedback and conversational evaluations. Psychologists ask questions to their patients and check to see if they fit the criteria for depression outlined in a book called the DSM, Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders, published by the American Psychiatric Association.

However, there's so much more we can do right now as individuals and a collective community to improve our understanding of depression and the general level of treatment at large instead of chalking everything up to an unexplainable "chemical imbalance in the brain" that only doctors and prescription medicine can solve. In fact, many professional psychiatrists, psychologists and pharmaceutical companies today may be just as confused as the rest of us about the underlying causes of clinical depression. Dr. Daniel Carlat, a renowned clinical professor of psychiatry at Tufts University School of Medicine, covered this very topic in his 2010 book, *Unhinged: The Trouble with Psychiatry - A Doctor's Revelations*

about a Profession in Crisis. Dr. Carlat emphasizes that the current psychiatric community places undue emphasis on psychopharmacology (the study of the use of medications in treating mental disorders) while convincing ourselves that we now have cures for mental illnesses “when in fact we know so little about the underlying neurobiology of their causes that our treatments are often a series of trials and errors.”<sup>17</sup>

It’s not all bad news, however. Cognitive Behavioral Therapy or CBT has proven to be very effective and promising for treating depression in the psychotherapy community. CBT is intriguing because it focuses on how your thoughts and feelings lead to behavioral patterns, and teaches you to notice and change your negative habitual patterns by challenging your own thoughts, similar to what we discussed in the first section. As disappointed as I was in Katie’s campus psychiatrist, I do still have a lot of hope and respect for doctors and therapists out there who genuinely care about their patients, continue to create groundbreaking research and are skilled in different forms of therapy such as CBT. Based on my experiences, I can definitely say with confidence that not all psychiatrists, psychologists and psychotherapists are “created equal.” Some are better than others, by a mile. Some are absolutely terrible and care more about money than their patients

Furthermore, researchers and academics are constantly improving their understanding of clinical depression all over the world. For example, in 2015, the PNAS scientific journal published that meditating, exercising and spending time in nature are highly effective in preventing rumination and overactivity in the

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17 Carlat, Daniel J. (2010). *Unhinged: the Trouble with Psychiatry--a Doctors Revelations about a Profession in Crisis*. Free Press.

brain.<sup>18</sup> According to the study, participants who went on a 90-min walk through nature reported lower levels of rumination and showed reduced neural activity in an area of the brain linked to risk of mental illness compared with those who walked through an urban environment. Studies also show that maintaining a nutrient-rich diet, journaling about emotions, engaging in art/music therapy, exposing yourself daily to sunlight and spending time to bond with others all help in fighting depression by helping you regain a balanced level of neurotransmitters such as dopamine, serotonin and oxytocin. As much as I want to expand on every single one of those important findings, there's already plenty of great literature out there on each of those topics so I encourage you to read them (some of them are below). If I were to highlight three topics in particular, it would be nutrition, physical exercise and social support. Speaking as someone who's experienced and recovered from major depression before, understanding and improving those three aspects were major game changers for my own recovery.

Here's a short list of great books that I most recommend on the topic of defeating depression, handling rumination and understanding our brain:

- *Change Your Brain, Change Your Life: The Breakthrough Program for Conquering Anxiety, Depression, Obsessiveness, Lack of Focus, Anger, and Memory Problems* by Daniel G. Amen
- *Brain Rules: 12 Principles for Surviving and Thriving at Work, Home, and School* by John Medina

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18 Bratman, Gregory N., et al. (2015). "Nature experience reduces rumination and subgenual prefrontal cortex activation." *Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences*, 112(28): 8567–8572. doi:10.1073/pnas.1510459112.

- Feeling Good: The New Mood Therapy by David D. Burns.
- The Depression Cure: The 6-Step Program to Beat Depression without Drugs by Stephen S. Ilardi
- How God Changes Your Brain: Breakthrough Findings from a Leading Neuroscientist by Andrew Newberg and Mark Robert Waldman
- Stress-Proof: The Scientific Solution to Protect Your Brain and Body--and Be More Resilient Every Day by Mithu Storoni
- How to Stop Worrying and Start Living by Dale Carnegie

Although we are still currently unable to pinpoint the exact causes of depression today, if we were to integrate the efforts of experienced healthcare professionals and researchers with our own individual efforts, depression may be more effectively understood and treated all over the world. As it stands now, there's no denying that there's so much more we need to discover about how depression works.

The following is the rest of my interview with Dr. Ebesutani. We talked about the impact of culture, history and economics on the depression and suicide epidemic in South Korea.

Terry: "Dr. Ebesutani, what do you think about South Korea's unique relationship with depression today?"

Dr. Ebesutani: "There seems to be two worlds trying to integrate. New Korea & Old Korea. Parents & Children. East & West. Modern & Traditional. They are trying to integrate and they don't know how. And I believe this is causing a lot of pain in Korea, as there is a lack of understanding of each other leading to social

conflict.

Another factor affecting depression in Korea, I think, is that society is still built upon rigid structures, hierarchies and order. While these things do have their merit and can help societies, such as helping to stabilize systems, I believe they are hard on individuals. In rigid systems, you often need to give up choice and your desire to pursue what is individually meaningful to you. There's pros and cons with that. But I do believe that overly rigid hierarchies, order, and structures can harm individuals.

The third factor that I see affecting depression in Korea are, ironically, the close-knit relationships here. Koreans value connecting with each other and Korea is a very close-knit society. Koreans worry a lot about each other. And they genuinely care about each other. The general Korean mindset seems to be: "I genuinely care about you. We are connected and I need to take care of you." For example, there's frequent mixing of money, helping each other financially through family, relatives and friends. People also make comments to each other on personal matters, mostly out of concern. While this can be positive, I do see the negative side effects of being too closely intertwined in relationships. Things get messy, and people get hurt. There's a lot of unwanted intrusion into people's lives."

Terry: "What do you think about the impact of South Korean parent-child relationships on their mental health?"

Dr. Ebesutani: "This is a complicated and difficult question to answer. My opinion is this. When Koreans recovered from the IMF crisis, they sacrificed their individual desires and pooled money and efforts together to keep the country alive. It's definitely

related to the Korean culture—if you want to do something great, you need others and sacrifice yourself to do something as a group. Korea has proven that. Koreans are willing to sacrifice themselves for their family and their country like they did for IMF, and parents do the same for their children. Some influences include Confucianism, and the ideas of group harmony over individual desires.

I work with lots of international Korean students who studied abroad and have become westernized. They definitely do not see the same world as their parents. Korean parents tend to have high standards and also want their children to try hard to live a better life than their own because they had to make many hard sacrifices in the past. So they force their children to live a “better” life that they think they should live.

Children are thus often criticized and rarely praised, disciplining them often in order to keep their children achieving more and more, which leads to long-term stress, anger and frustration in their relationships. Korean children become angry at their parents and the world. The parents’ perspective is that they are sacrificing so much for their children and their family so their children should sacrifice to meet their demands as well to be able to live a better life. But that generational integration is not happening very well. We need to find ways to better support that.”

I sincerely thank Dr. Ebesutani again for his gracious support. I was deeply moved by his willingness to accept my request for an interview out of his busy schedule and his words of encouragement for me to continue writing this book.

## Chapter 14

# Awareness and Presence

There is a popular saying that goes “A fish does not know it’s wet.” To a fish, being wet and living completely submerged in water are completely normal. Similarly, our brains often don’t realize when they are in the middle of harmful rumination or overthinking. Especially for a person whose overthinking has become second nature, it’s difficult for them to notice in the moment that they are actually ruminating. For example, if you have a long-held habit of biting your nails, touching your hair or shaking your legs, you don’t even realize your own body is actively doing those things until minutes later. It is the same with ruminating. Unknown to yourself, obsessive rumination has the power to pull you in and harm you in the long run, much like a tiny parasite inside your mind that you can’t detect but just won’t go away. Rumination can be quite addictive in that way. Our brains seem to be biased toward focusing on powerful negative emotions like anger, shame, envy, and regret.

That’s why improving your own awareness of your thoughts and emotions is crucial. Essentially, this will help you catch yourself every time a ruminative loop is occurring or about to occur. Being present is similar. When you keep practicing the ability to bring yourself back to the present moment by engaging fully with your senses, you are able to turn off other mental processes, like obsessive rumination, that may have been taxing your mind. You’ve probably experienced a few glimpses of such intense presence before. Whether in the middle of watching an intense sports

game with friends or playing an exciting game of ball game yourself, you are right there in the middle of the action with no time or space to think. Other such experiences might include seeing a breathtaking, beautiful view from the top of a mountain, riding a thrilling roller coaster or watching a touching, tear-jerking movie. In such engaging and absorbing experiences, you completely lose your track of time and become completely engaged in whatever you are actively doing. In such a state of high presence, it becomes easier for us to enjoy the sensation of being alive in the present moment and appreciate every second of it.



It's hard not to pay attention to the present moment when  
you are skydiving 200 miles per hour toward the Earth

Practicing presence is a bit similar to that. However, instead of needing an adrenaline-pumping activity to get yourself into that zone, you decide to center the present moment in your awareness, no matter what you are doing at the time. You may even be doing something quite mundane like washing dishes, watering your plants, riding the subway on your morning commute or waiting in line at the grocery store. But you still choose to completely engage with the present moment, no matter how seemingly unglamorous or uneventful it may be. Practicing presence is not as easy as it sounds because in today's world of endless digital stimuli in the form of Snapchat, Instagram, Twitter, mobile app push notifications and more, there is an overwhelming amount of distraction

out there that can pull you off presence at any second. But the more you practice presence, the better you will get at it.

In neuroscience, there's a fascinating concept called "neuroplasticity," which says that your brain is capable of changing, growing and learning until your death. Instead of being fixed to a pre-defined capacity as some used to believe, your brain can literally rewire itself and change its own capacity based on the lifestyle you adhere to, the habits you implement and even the thoughts that you think. MRI scans of the brain seem to show that neurons are specifically activated or deactivated depending on the thoughts and activities one engages in. A specific brain area is engaged when you are visualizing yourself playing basketball, and then there's a completely different network that's engaged when you are thinking lovely thoughts about your significant other. And since every single neuron is a building block of your brain, we can reasonably say that we really are the sculptors of our own brain. Every day, with every thought, we can consciously make choices that will be helpful for our brain.

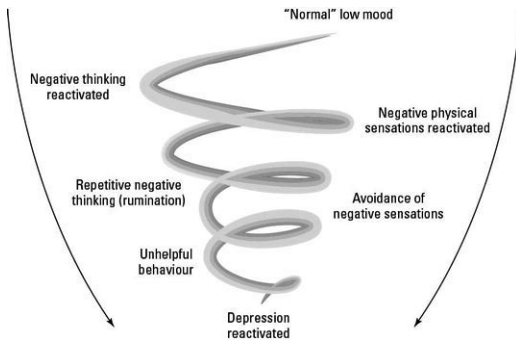
This is why choosing your own environment may be so important for your brain. As adults, we have a certain level of freedom and responsibility when it comes to the influences we choose to let inside our lives. I'm not saying you should just avoid every person who says negative things to you, but generally speaking, you must carefully consider all elements in your surroundings, including friends, family, co-workers, TV shows, social media influencers and even the people you follow on Instagram. Then ask yourself, "Is this person's influence helping me and my brain's health, or is it hurting me?"

Start being more aware of your present moment today. Be aware of your ruminative stories, emotional triggers, and the mental in-

fluence that other people in your environment may have on your brain. Choose to surround yourself with people and things that make you feel peaceful, inspired and grateful to be alive.

## Chapter 15

# Downward Spiral, Upward Spiral



A downward spiral of depression

Depression is sometimes referred to as a “downward spiral,” similar to the Domino Effect. Initially, there’s some kind of life event or trigger that impacts you and puts you into a state of chronic stress. Because you feel lethargic and depressed, you stop going out or hanging with your friends. Because you stop going out or interacting with people, you feel even more stressed, lonely and isolated. Because you are lonely and have more time by yourself, you start ruminating more harmful thoughts on your own which creates even more stress. Now you may even resort to self-soothing behaviors such as binge-eating sugary or fatty foods. You start gaining weight and feeling more unattractive. And now because you feel unattractive, you become even more critical of yourself,

isolate yourself further and stop going out altogether while distracting yourself with TV or video games. You dig yourself into a deeper and deeper hole everyday because of this negative momentum. As your spiral gets worse and worse, you feel like there's no way out, completely hopeless.

This “downward spiral” concept may be closely connected to how the neurotransmitter dopamine works, which is heavily impacted when one is clinically depressed. When dopamine levels are out of balance, you may experience a severe lack of motivation and interest in daily activities that you would normally find pleasurable. As a result, you stop doing the very activities—such as exercising, socializing or accomplishing daily tasks—that will help balance out your neurotransmitter levels. In fact, you may even begin to crave only highly stimulating activities that promise an easy release of high dopamine. These activities may include binge-eating, taking drugs, smoking, overindulging in addictive videogames or pornography, and more. The frequent release of high dopamine through these channels of immediate gratification may then result in a long-term dopamine “tolerance” of sorts, preventing your brain from returning to normal equilibrium levels. In that state, where your brain is now used to pumping out high amounts of dopamine all the time, you may feel completely unmotivated with other tasks in daily life, and the only thing your brain looks forward to will be the next high from another immediate gratification. The built-in reward system of the brain will keep getting unhealthier once you are on this train. You may continue to feel that long-term beneficial activities such as physical exercise or studying are “low-reward” and not worth doing because the other immediate gratification activities have now hijacked your brain's inherent “reward system.”

On the contrary, a person in an optimistic, happy mental state may have a much easier time staying optimistic and happy due to the concept of the “upward spiral,” which is essentially the complete opposite of the downward spiral. By obtaining a series of small wins, one thing leads to another, and your positive momentum starts snowballing into an unstoppable force that drives you to be happier every day. The initial spark of an upward spiral can come from anywhere. For example, you decide to commit to improving your physical health and start exercising a few times a week. Because of this regular exercise, you now feel great and have more energy. Because you have more energy, you feel more motivated to cook at night instead of eating junk food. Because you cook and exercise more, you start losing weight as well as looking better in general. Because you look better, you feel better about yourself and start thinking more positive thoughts instead of ruminating at home. Because you start feeling more confident from your thoughts, you may even venture outside and go hang out with your friends. You then feel great from having a social activity and bonding with friends. And the positive cycle continues.

Similar to a downward spiral, an upward spiral might be related to how dopamine and motivation work together in your brain. You are in a chain reaction of one positive action creating a positive feeling or a result, making you even more motivated to take that next action. It is essentially a continuous “feedback loop” consisting of small positive actions followed by small positive results. At the same time, you gradually lose the urge to gravitate only toward immediately gratifying behaviors because you are now using the built-in reward system of the brain for you instead of against you. That may be why you often see fitness junkies who

become obsessed with going to the gym daily for their “gains.” They start gaining tremendous satisfaction from a daily improvement in their physique and just keep taking more and more action, bringing themselves to the gym tirelessly for more results. As a side note, I want to remind you again (at the risk of sounding like a broken record) that physical exercise is a proven measure for preventing and treating depression. It has an incredible list of benefits that includes lowering the stress hormone cortisol, increasing testosterone, balancing neurotransmitters, improving your self-esteem and immune system, and more. There’s a timeless universal adage across multiple cultures that “A strong body makes a strong mind.” I wholeheartedly encourage and recommend all types of physical activities such as weightlifting, running, walking, HIIT cardio, yoga, sports, martial arts and more because they will help enhance your mental and emotional strength as well.

I myself learned about the concept of downward and upward spirals from psychology experts and found them resonating with my own experiences from depression. My recovery started with that one initial decision to phone a friend or try a new therapy program. By breaking the usual pattern of activities that kept me in a downward spiral, I was eventually able to find a way out of that negative momentum and start my own upward spiral little by little. If you’d like to learn more about this concept, there’s another great book on this very topic called *The Upward Spiral: Using Neuroscience to Reverse the Course of Depression, One Small Change at a Time* by Alex Korb.

## Chapter 16

# The Power of Appreciation

When we look at the different types of rumination and harmful obsessive thought patterns from the first section, they all have one problem in common. “I am not good enough.” “I am so ugly.” “I am so behind.” “I should have done that.” “I must be like that.” Can you spot the underlying problem?

It’s called a “scarcity mentality,” where a person feels a strong sense of lack in themselves, and they believe they need something or that they need to be somebody else in order to feel complete. You don’t feel enough in being yourself. You are not content with what you are now, what you have now, and where you are now, but always looking for something more than what is available to you in the present. I’m not saying it’s wrong to want more from your life or to be ambitious. But when your mind is always wanting and needing something more while failing to see the beauty in the things you already have, it may cause suffering.

Interestingly, the scarcity mentality works differently from most of our other human needs and desires. For example, when you are hungry, you grab some food and feel full, so you don’t feel that hunger anymore. When you are thirsty, you grab some water, and then your thirst is quenched. The scarcity mindset keeps you thirsty no matter what you do. It’s a trap. Even if you fulfill it once, it keeps bothering you because you want even more than what you wanted initially. For example, you go for a higher-paying job be-

cause you believe money will make you happier. Once you get that job, you want even more money. You thought you'd be happy once you earn \$70,000 but now that you are there, you wish you were earning \$100,000. You used to compare yourself to people in your middle-class neighborhood, now you compare yourself to people living in luxury apartments. In this way, inner peace and scarcity mindset are in complete conflict with each other.

The advice from this chapter is something you may already have heard a thousand times before from your grandparents or even during a church sermon from your pastor. The best way to handle your scarcity mindset is to constantly engage in the act of appreciation. The very act of consciously focusing on the blessings you have in your life and being thankful for every single one of them helps you develop the crucial perspective you need to fight a scarcity mindset. It's not only the general philosophy of appreciation that's important but also the actual practice of reminding yourself as frequently as possible, which will then lead to a direct impact on your brain activity. Below is a list of things we easily take for granted in our modern lives:

- You have a healthy body. You can walk, run, climb stairs or play sports. There's those born with genetic defects or without healthy functioning bodies.
- You have the gift of sight, hearing and feeling. Some are born mute, blind or deaf.
- You have freedom. You have the freedom to see your friends, eat a nice meal, walk outside, watch TV and buy and wear nice clothes. There's those without such fundamental freedom in prison or other forms of confinement.

- You have somewhere to live. There's plenty of people and adults without their own rooms or even a roof over their head.
- You have a group of friends. You can hang out and have fun together. There's plenty of people without friends.
- You are young. There's plenty of people who wish they could go back and be in their teens, 20s or 30s again.
- You went to school. You can read. You have a basic understanding of math, English and/or sciences. There's plenty of people who were not fortunate enough to receive formal education.
- You have a family. There are people who love you. There's others without any family or friends out there.

Remember it's the daily practice of appreciation that counts. Experts recommend the "gratitude exercise" where you dedicate fifteen minutes every day to write down a list of five to ten things you are the most grateful for. Literally counting all your abundant blessings daily can help you maintain your presence throughout the day, so your brain doesn't jump to another scarcity-based rumination about how you wish you had this or how you are a failure because of X. There's also a great iOS app on the App Store called Bold built by a personal friend that allows you to log your gratitude list on your phone with daily reminders.

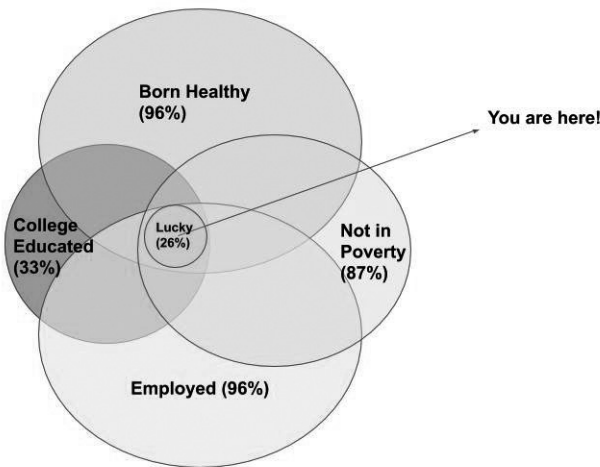
Another good way to gain perspective on your good fortune is to do a visualization exercise. We are going to compare you to the rest of the world, the entire population of about 7.7 billion people living on Earth. I'm going to assume that you are American. Considering that the current population of the U.S. is around 300 million, you literally won a 4% lottery, considering that it's a privi-

lege to have been born and to live in the U.S., one of the wealthiest countries in the world. You don't have to worry everyday about the lack of food or clean water, diseases, natural catastrophes or violent military regimes like the citizens of some other countries. That alone puts you at the top 4% of the luckiest people in the world. Still not feeling lucky enough? Let's keep going.

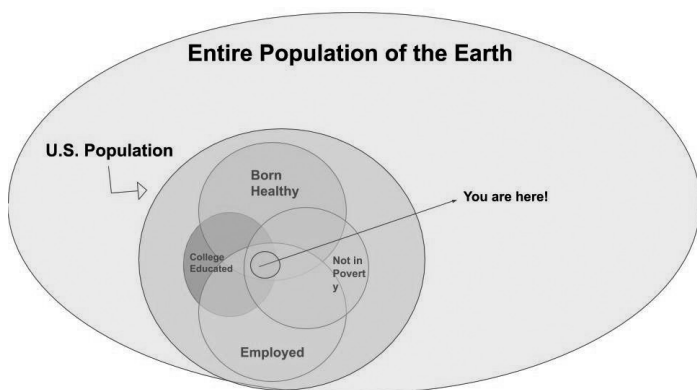
With every blessing, you realize that you are in a smaller and smaller pool of people who don't have those blessings all at the same time. The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention estimates that birth defects occur in about 1 in every 33 infants born in the United States each year. So if you are a healthy young adult, you were lucky enough to be among 96% of the perfectly healthy people in the country without a serious birth defect. Now, I'm going to also assume you and your family are not dirt poor or living homeless in the streets. According to the Census Bureau, the estimated poverty rate of the U.S. in 2016 was around 13%. So you are now placed among the 83% of the luckiest young adults in the country who were born perfectly healthy and are not living in poverty. Now, if you also happen to have a college degree, lucky you, that puts you among 33% of the U.S. population that have a bachelor's degree or higher. So let's add that to the math. One last thing: assume you are also a functioning adult with a job. That's an even smaller pool, given that the unemployment rate in March 2019 was about 4%, according to the Bureau of Labor Statistics. Now, you are a blessed part of the 96% (who are gainfully employed), out of the 33% college educated, out of the 83% of people who are healthy and not living in poverty. This comes out to—drum roll please!—an astounding 26% of the entire country. And, if you are an American, having all these blessings combined puts you among the 1% luckiest people of the entire global population

of 7.7 billion!

As a side note, I'm only skimming the surface of these actual statistics and are simplifying them for illustrating a point. A math teacher friend of mine was kind enough to correct me in that the actual end percentage might be much higher than 1% because we are not talking about completely independent events. For example, the probability of being born with a genetic defect directly impacts the probability of being unemployed so they would not be independent from each other. I want you to take the exact math with a grain of salt, but know that you are one extremely lucky star in this world. Instead of throwing a bunch of numbers at you, here's a couple of visual representations below that summarize this idea.



I'd like to title this Venn diagram "How Lucky You Are"



Think of yourself from the perspective of the entire world (represented by the giant oval). If you live in the U.S., you are among the second inner circle. And if you are employed, college-educated, not poor and were born without birth defects, you are then even a smaller part of that inner circle.

Isn't that crazy? We are constantly competing with each other on who has a better job or a bigger house, makes more money, or has more followers on Instagram, but that's like 1% of the most privileged group of people in the entire world bickering over "who's got it better." From the perspective of someone living in a third-world country, born blind or disabled, unemployed and living in poverty without the ability to read, aren't you one of the most blessed people alive?

## Chapter 17

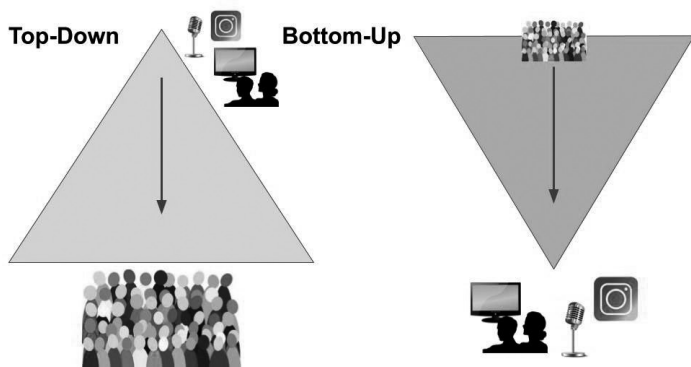
# Top-Down, Bottom-Up

Once you gain a better control over your mind's rumination and learn to live in the present moment with an invigorating upward spiral, you will generally be feeling much better. It does not mean you won't drift off-course now and then; you will still have your share of setbacks, stressful emotions and negative thoughts. However, you will be much better at handling the passing waves of different emotions and thoughts, and generating a more constant level of stability on your own. Also, by healing yourself first, you are then able to project that peace toward others and live each day with integrity, confidence and energy that others can benefit from. Once your state of joy gains momentum, you can choose to extend that energy to others, impacting people around you positively like a Domino Effect.

In an ideal world, every single person would be completely healed by a combination of appropriate treatment and healthy mental habits. But because our brains are quite fragile against external influences, there's no way our inner peace can continue thriving if we keep ourselves trapped inside an environment that's not conducive to preventing and healing depression as a whole. Like a healthy flower trapped inside an over-crowded pot of weeds, you may wither and revert back your progress. Our progress at the individual level has to be accompanied by a much bigger change at the societal and cultural level as well.

An effective way to impact a large group of people and their

mindsets in a shorter amount of time may be mass communication and media. I see the need for a fundamental change in the messages that come from the “Top-Down”—meaning the thought leaders, authority figures, content creators and influential voices of the world—on the topic of depression and mental health. All the active “Bottom-Up” efforts from the everyday individuals such as you and I, who implement healthy mental habits to heal ourselves, need to be echoed by those at the top who have a massive reach when it comes to spreading awareness through the news, TV, social media and other channels. A small handful of people meditating daily and talking about healing their brains might positively impact each other, and there’s nothing wrong with that. But imagine the great impact of those few voices that can influence millions of people at once to change the conversation about depression and to motivate young adults to take a chance on changing their mental habits. In today’s digital age, somebody with that kind of influence can impact an entire generation on the other side of a continent.



Top-Down influence comes from the top thought leaders at the forefront of mass communication, entertainment and media toward the general public.

Bottom-Up influence comes from individuals like you and I and can be used to impact those influential thought leaders at the top to speak on our behalf and accurately reflect the values of the public.

Many influencers on Instagram and social media today have this kind of impact and power. In 2019, the K-pop boy group BTS announced that it had reached 20 million Twitter and Instagram followers. The age demographic of its fans vary greatly between 11 to 40 years old, and its international fandom stretches across countries like the Philippines, Thailand, Vietnam, India, France, Brazil, Mexico, the U.S. and more. Whatever they say on TV or post on Instagram is instantly made news by fans all over the world who soak up their messages like sponges. That's the power of Top-Down influence. And this is not unique to BTS. I wouldn't be surprised if the plastic surgery epidemic in the general young adult population in South Korea had been largely ignited by their celebrities. Boys and girls want to imitate the looks of celebrities they see and admire on television. But instead of merely swaying

young adults toward fashion trends or the latest looks, such influential individuals may be able to spread game-changing ideas on mental health, culture and values. It will certainly be a stretch to convince these celebrities and teenagers to reduce plastic surgery or spread awareness about depression, but ideas conveyed by influential voices have the power to sway many people into a new course of action.

Correcting public perception and broadcasting helpful information about depression at a larger scale may be an important catalyst for change. Just look at the current treatment of depression as a mental illness, and you will see that the general public's level of understanding of this condition is still incredibly low. We must communicate the idea that depression is a complex, multi-layered problem that combines psychological, biological, economical and cultural factors and more. However, a big portion of the uninformed public is still attributing the illness to "mental weakness" or a chemical imbalance in the brain that only prescription medication can solve.

It would take a large team of intelligent minds from different disciplines to correctly triangulate the causes of depression and the rising suicide epidemic. However, just like it's possible for an individual to recover from major depression with enough understanding and effort, it's possible for a community and also a country to do the same. The key to speedy progress and change, whether they are initiated by the influencers at the top or the individuals at the bottom, may be a well-integrated and synchronized effort from both of those directions.

## Chapter 18

# “An Idle Mind is the Devil’s Workshop”

The title of this chapter is a well-known proverb from 1855 credited to a British publisher named H.G. Bohn. It suggests that when you are too bored or have little to occupy your mind with, you might be tempted to think harmful thoughts or otherwise do instantly gratifying things that may harm you in the long-run. I completely agree with it in respect to rumination and depression. It is very difficult to keep your mind off of negative thoughts when you have a lot of time to think and not much to do.

When you have improved your ability to notice your negative thought-patterns and replace them with positive habits and self-talk, you will gain a level of freedom from all the things that used to take up your time in the past. At this stage, you may face this new problem of having more time on your hands than you ever had before. What do you do now that you have all this free time and energy? How can you prevent yourself from having an “idle mind?” When you used to suffer from rumination, you might have had little time to concentrate on your goals or ambitions in life. But now that you are no longer trapped in the past or terrified of the future, you will need to fill your mind in the present with activities that inspire and engage you. Otherwise, you may become vulnerable to having an “idle” mind and revert back to your old habit of rumination, possibly inviting a “devil’s workshop” into your mind again.

Engaging yourself daily in a line of work that you are truly passionate about, or in a hobby that fires you up would be my short answer, but I cannot give you a concrete answer on what you should be pursuing specifically. I do not know your particular interests, talents or inclinations. But whatever you decide to do, I would like to recommend that you occupy your mind with something meaningful or worthwhile to you where you also get to meet other interesting, passionate and uplifting people. The world is full of mentors and partners who can help you in your journey if you open yourself up to reaching out to others and learning from them. You may even serve as a mentor or a coach yourself and derive satisfaction from helping others. Like I mentioned a hundred times already, maintaining and creating positive social bonds are crucial for your mental health.

I also would like to recommend that you explore a variety of activities to engage your mind and open yourself up to different kinds of experiences. It is said that our brain loves experiencing novel stimuli, and exposure to different environments and activities may help expand our brain and release dopamine. This is not to say you should go nuts with shopping sprees for new items or experiment with dangerous activities, but instead, try to challenge yourself often with new experiences that engage your mind. They will pay dividends when it comes to keeping negative thoughts at bay and enriching your mind with learning, confidence and joy from new experiences.

Thanks to the advancement of technology and mobile apps, it's becoming easier than ever to find people with similar hobbies and interests and share fun experiences together. For those of you interested in meeting new people for a variety of group activities,

I recommend Meetup.com. For those of you who love singing, there's an amazingly addictive mobile app called Smule (on iOS and Android) where you can collaborate with singers all over the world and record songs together, even on video (It's also a wonderful way to make new friends!). For those interested in language exchange and learning new languages with native speakers from all over the world, I recommend apps like HelloTalk and Speaky. For those interested in performing comedy in front of live audiences, I recommend you search Google for the nearest Open Mics (BadSlava.com is great). The world is your oyster and full of possibilities for you to participate in. Don't get stuck in a rut. Keep yourself busy for your own mind's sake. I cannot wait to hear about your unique adventures.

## Chapter 19

# Faith, Spirituality and My Testimony

I want this book to be helpful for everyone out there, whether or not you follow a certain religion. But from my own personal experience, I'd like to tell you with strong conviction that spirituality can be extremely helpful for your mental health and serve as a strong shield against depression. I would like to share my story of how I ended up developing my faith as a result of fighting depression.

Although I begrudgingly attended Christian churches since I was a little boy in Seoul, I did not develop a serious faith in God until after my bouts with suicidal depression in my late 20s. It was only after I came out of my worst depressive episode that I began to appreciate the importance of faith. It was an extremely humbling occasion, and quite a surprising event for others who had always known me as a religious skeptic. I felt as though God was forcing me to change my entire mindset toward life. I was once a privileged kid filled with anger, self-hatred, regret, dissatisfaction and resistance. I was dissatisfied with my lot in life and always restless looking for something better on the horizon. After God saved me from depression, everything changed.

When Katie died in her junior year in college, I was still 16 years old and a relatively normal high school kid with no major signs of mental complications. I was slightly introverted but always tried to be the class clown making jokes. I did have a problem

with bullies in school due to my language barrier (learning English as a second language) and conflict-avoidant nature which caused many sleepless nights of angry rumination as a teenager. I was obviously very distressed when Katie died and wasn't completely functional in school for many months after her incident, but slowly got back into the swing of things and looked forward to leaving for college. One thing I distinctly remember from my last months in high school is when a classmate found out through the grapevine that Katie had died from committing suicide. He wasn't exactly a friend, and I really detested him when he came by and gave me his unsolicited opinion: "Hey, is it true that your dead sister had depression? You know, I think depression is just all in the head. There's no such thing as depression. It's just weakness." If I could go back in time now, I would probably give him a hard punch in the face and then ask him not to judge things he does not fully understand.

Since my early 20s, I've been diagnosed with clinical depression three times at different points in my life. Each episode had its own circumstances and a unique cocktail of possible causes that put me in a very vulnerable mental state. The first few times were in my junior and senior years in college, similar to Katie. In those days, I remember being deeply concerned with how I was coming across to my peers on campus and ruminating frequently on my social interactions with others. I was often stressed out from relationship difficulties, especially from romantic breakups. College was almost like a blessing and a curse; I was so glad to meet so many new people and make new friends but it was also overwhelming for me at times trying to fit into different cliques and friend groups. I was definitely uncomfortable with being judged

negatively by others and tried to get along with everybody, which might have contributed to my stress. I had to learn from experience that sometimes you just can't please everyone, and you will be misunderstood and judged by others no matter how hard you try. But at the time, every single person who thought negatively of me felt like such a big deal, and was a major source of my ruminative thoughts and distressing feelings.

In my senior year of college, another major trigger to my depression was the sheer amount of stress over job-searching and securing a job offer after graduation. When I started getting rejected in my early job interviews, it made a big dent in my self-esteem. Looking back, I might have just been very hard on myself; not everyone gets to work at the number one company of their choice right after their college graduation. Nevertheless, I felt embarrassed to share this with my friends and tell them that I was struggling with job interviews. Maybe similar to Katie, I had been afraid of being vulnerable and opening up about my struggles to anyone. Perhaps I wanted my friends to see me as perfect and invulnerable; I didn't want to seem stupid and weak. I might have tried to bottle up all those feelings to myself.

My symptoms would be mild in the beginning and get exponentially worse over a few months. I would often feel incredibly tired and oversleep for 14 to 16 hours a day. Sleep was my escapism method of choice, almost a welcome refuge from my obsessive stream of negative thoughts. I had trouble focusing in class and isolated myself further and further everyday. I holed myself up in my room, and friends started wondering where I was or what was wrong with me since I usually had such a happy personality. I also noticed that my cognitive abilities suffered. I couldn't remember

things clearly and would fumble over my words when talking to people. I had very low energy and walked around the campus like a zombie. I was binge-eating unhealthy food, binge-watching television to avoid feeling lonely and essentially trying to run away from all the problems in my life. I felt helpless, alone, stupid and embarrassed.

I eventually went to the university mental health clinic and was prescribed Celexa, Lexapro and other SSRI medications at different occasions by campus psychiatrists. When I told the therapists at the clinic about the various problems I was struggling with such as job-searching, rumination and relationship conflicts, they listened to me for a little bit but never offered me any concrete solutions or tips. They kept wanting me to come back to their office after the medication kick in, which is understandable but after some unproductive sessions, I lost confidence in them and felt like I was wasting my time.

All in all, it was my caring friends and family who truly helped me every time. During the worst phases of my depression, my closest friends and family talked to me, listened to my worries, encouraged me, emphasized with me and helped me stop my ruminations. They socialized with me as much as they can over lunches, dinners and social occasions. When I was with them, I realized that my incessant rumination would stop for just a bit, and it'd be easier for me to be more engaged with the present moment. Those supportive social interactions might have given me a temporary "time-out" which then helped me feel significantly better afterwards. Generally after about four to five months from the start of an episode, my depression would gradually taper off, and I would start feeling better enough to engage with daily tasks again in a more stable state. But there's no doubt that every re-

covery was made possible by the support of the people around me.

My latest and worst episode of depression came in my late 20s a few months after my 27th birthday. This time, the trigger was due to a romantic breakup and all the emotional drama that ensued afterwards. I couldn't focus at work or stop ruminating for months on end. I was filled with unnecessary guilt over what had happened with an ex-girlfriend and kept blaming myself for things that now look incredibly insignificant in hindsight. I noticed that I became even more emotionally vulnerable during romantic relationships, especially toward my romantic partner's negative comments. During the worst phases of this depression, what helped me the most were listening to sermons from my pastor at church and praying to God. In a particular sermon, I almost felt like the pastor was talking directly to me when he preached to the congregation, "Love the hardships in your life just as much as you love life's blessings. God giveth and God taketh away. If you become angry at God for giving you hard times, then that also means you don't deserve all the good that God gives you. Learn to appreciate every single small blessing instead of complaining or blaming God for not giving you what you think you deserve. Gladly endure the hardships in your life. God never tests you with something that you cannot overcome. " I was deeply moved by the message of this sermon. It was such a different perspective from how I had been approaching problems all my life, complaining and wishing things had turned out better. Although it took another six months from the time of this sermon to my complete recovery, the pastor's message stayed with me and helped me stay strong through my difficulties.

Since my most recent recovery, I've decided to approach faith in a completely different way. It wasn't just that single sermon that transformed me but committing myself to living a life for God helped me adopt a very different attitude toward life than the one I had before. I used to be very engrossed in myself and my mistakes, shortcomings and regrets, and those were all major sources of my constant rumination and eventual depression. Today, I am still aware of my imperfections but feel more connected to the bigger universe outside of my own small mind and how lucky we are to be alive here on Earth. I am much more grateful for every single day and all the blessings we are given such as health, love, friendships and experiences. I find it much easier to forgive myself and love others. And it's all thanks to the kind, loving and selfless people around me who helped guide me down this path.

Faith in God might sound like spiritual mumbo-jumbo to some, but even from a neuroscientific perspective, it may be fruitful. Many religious activities such as praying and meditating have been found to elicit different frequencies of brain waves that are healing, relaxing and anti-depressive.<sup>19 20</sup> Priests, monks and spiritual healers have long used praying and meditating as a way of strengthening their spirituality and surrendering to the present moment which directly fights the habit of harmful ruminating and concentrating solely on the "self." Many religious teachings encourage their followers to be completely receptive and aware of the "now," and surrender their mind to "what is" instead of fighting

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19 Ross, Ashail. (2015, November 24). "TLC for your heart and brain: Meditation and prayer!" Healthy Beginnings, [www.hbmag.com/tlc-for-your-heart-and-brain-meditation-and-prayer/](http://www.hbmag.com/tlc-for-your-heart-and-brain-meditation-and-prayer/).

20 Spector, Nicole. (2017, October 20). "What the brain looks like when you pray." NBCNews.com, [www.nbcnews.com/better/health/your-brain-prayer-meditation-ncna812376](http://www.nbcnews.com/better/health/your-brain-prayer-meditation-ncna812376).

“what is wrong” with their reality. Buddhism specifically teaches its followers to elevate their level of consciousness through the practice of meditation, compassion, self-restraint and letting go of the mind’s attachments. Another thing to note is that activities such as communal singing, group praying, listening to sermons and the act of gathering together for a shared purpose may help release the “social” hormone oxytocin and have a direct, beneficial impact on your brain. It’s also another way to prevent yourself from isolation.

I advise you to try to separate stereotypes of certain religions from the main messages within the spiritual teachings themselves. Personally, I’ve been able to find some truth and wisdom in almost every religious or philosophical text. If you do happen to be curious about the concept (and practice) of spirituality, I would suggest that you start by reading religious texts yourself, instead of blindly accepting any one belief as dogma.

Lastly, I want to keep stressing on the beneficial effects of meditation, although they are already well-known. Meditation has become a huge part of my own personal transformation, and it’s something that will dramatically improve your ability to combat depression and life stressors. When it comes to quieting negative thoughts and learning how to focus on the present moment, I have found no better practice than meditating at least 15 minutes a day, first thing in the morning after waking up. Some mobile apps such as “Calm” and “Headspace” can also be used for guided and unguided meditation. I wholeheartedly encourage you to make meditation a daily practice, as it will make a huge impact on your mental health and your ability to resist harmful overthinking and self-defeating rumination.



# Dear Asian Parents

I cannot thank you enough for all the sacrifices you made for your children. Especially if you immigrated with your children to a foreign country, I am intimately familiar with the struggles you must have experienced as first-generation immigrants with minimum language skills and putting everything on the line for your children's education. I know you were discriminated against, mistreated, disrespected and looked down upon, but you did everything you could to support your children's future. I can only assume the pain you must have experienced for decades. No wonder you want your children to get into the best schools and get the best jobs. Any good parent would want their kids to have respectable, privileged jobs where they don't have to suffer. You wanted your children to have better lives.

I want you to know that I'm not blaming you for all the mental issues plaguing young Asian adults now. You had no hand in making up the rules for what "success" means or what kind of jobs are out there. The reason you push your children with such high expectations is because you just want the best for them. You want them to shine, live in the best places and be highly respected in the community. Of course you never wished your children to suffer from depression.

But what I am talking about in this book is not just about what you want from your children. This is about the larger world we live in, and the scarcity mindset that both you, the parents, and we, the children, decided to believe in and is hurting us on a major scale. It's about all of us having a bigger picture than just the honor of the family name. After all, the entire world is much bigger and more

important than just our family unit. We need to stop thinking only in terms of our family's happiness versus everyone else.

This is also not just about us children rebelling against authority. This is not about hot-blooded youth disobeying parents like bad children. It's about all of us accepting that we need to work together to fix what's unhealthy about our definition of success. It's about us recognizing that an unhealthy mindset will trickle down to the children, creating further generations with unhealthy mindsets. This is about us being humble enough to admit there's a problem we need to address. Our children are suffering so much that they report far more depression and suicides than previous generations. Do we need any more warning signs than that?

I do not blame my parents for what happened to my older sister. I love both Mom and Dad, and have no doubt that they did the best they could. However, it also does not mean I will forget about what happened. It wasn't only my parents' divorce, or Katie's experiences during childhood that impacted her sensitive mind. It was all of those things combined and more. Our current understanding of depression is so inadequate that even parents have little idea on how to support their depressed children or understand its possible causes. We have to improve together. And we have to ask more questions together instead of pointing fingers or chalking everything up to "weakness" or unexplainable neurochemistry that only pharmaceuticals can solve. Otherwise, we will continue to suffer generation after generation, family after family.

Next time you are about to scold your son for not getting a perfect report card in school or compare your daughter to some other successful child you know, I would like you to remember from this book that there is a strong correlation between mental narrative

(negative self-talk) and depression. So are you helping your child develop unconditional self-love or are you teaching them conditional approval? There is no need for all of our children to pursue only the top 1% of most prestigious academic programs or only the most prestigious career paths. When are we going to teach them how to live with confidence, emotional intelligence and courage? Are we considering the possibility that your child may be creatively gifted but not suited for traditional classrooms? Are we teaching them patience, kindness, compassion and humility just like Buddha, Confucius and Lao Tzu used to teach?

I'm not advocating that we let our children become lazy underperformers. But I am advocating that we decide once and for all what's really important for our children. Is it more important to have your child do exactly what you tell them to do and become exactly what you tell them to become, or to give them the courage to stretch their imagination in the future of possibilities? Is it more important for our children to become cut-throat competitive machines who only care about their self-interest or altruistic leaders who care about society as a whole? Because without your help and positive mental influence, more children may keep falling prey to depression.

Thank you again for all your efforts in raising and educating us. We are forever in your debt. If you are Asian-American, I appreciate your lifelong efforts of bringing us to a foreign country and sacrificing your personal goals for the good of the family. Thank you again for bringing us to a country where we could be better educated so that we are free to determine our own destiny and think independently. According to filial piety ingrained in us,

it's our duty to honor you and not let your efforts go in vain. So we honor your efforts by challenging ideas even greater than the ones you could have challenged. Even if that means we may disagree with what you used to tell us in the past. We must redefine the meaning of success for the good of everybody in this world. For you. For us. And for everyone else in this world regardless of ethnicity.

# Epilogue

I hope the information and observations in this book help guide you in the future, especially if you are someone who has experienced or are currently experiencing major depression. Here's a few final thoughts.

As you may already know, today's general recommendation for treating depression is a combination of prescription medication and psychotherapy. Although I do not doubt that this traditional combination can be effective for many, I also want you to remember everything else we've discussed in this book and consider all possible avenues to become a well-informed student of your own depression. You are an important part of the puzzle when it comes to understanding your own unique brain and its possible complications, stories, stress triggers and thought patterns. For a major subset of depression patients, it may be our mind's harmful thought patterns that are to blame for creating harmful, poisonous loops of rumination and chronic stress. This mental habit of rumination is incredibly difficult to be aware of and even harder to get rid of, and it might be impossible to tell with 100% certainty the exact origin of where your rumination might be stemming from. Activities such as meditation, physical exercise, spending time in nature and bonding socially with others, as well as refraining from highly addictive activities (such as excessive video games, drugs, alcohol dependence, pornography) have shown to be beneficial in healing your brain. Research shows us that we are literally able to sculpt our own brains by changing the way we think and the thought patterns we engage in daily. Like Buddha once said, "We are shaped by our thoughts; we become what we think."

Although the solution to depression is much more complex than “stop thinking negative thoughts,” I urge you to be more aware of your daily thoughts and find ways to fill your mind habitually with self-acceptance, appreciation and self-love. To help you on this quest, I would like to summarize three strategies below.

First, I want you to start talking to yourself more positively. How you talk to yourself is crucial when it comes to your mind's stories and your mental health. When you are unable to interpret your life events in a positive way, you start to see yourself and your life as worthless, leading to mental and emotional distress. Also, in a negative mood, your mind is prone to magnifying on only the negative aspects of your life. Katie's life was never as negative as she made it out to be, but it might have been her mind's distorted lens that stopped her from having an accurate sense of her reality. It may have been the obsessive rumination created by the overly judgmental “critic” inside Katie's mind that got in her way of seeing how wonderful she actually was. To maintain a healthy level of self-esteem, you must remind yourself frequently of your positive qualities, celebrate all of your small and large victories, and give yourself credit for all of your achievements. “Good job, me.” “Great job, me.” And freely offer that encouragement to others as well in your daily interactions. Your mind's ability to frame yourself and all of your life's experiences in a positive way is crucial to protect yourself from depression and create self-confidence in yourself.

Second, if you are a part of the South Korean or Asian demographic with a typical, strict upbringing from your parents, I want you to start challenging the established mindset of our culture. This does not mean disobey your parents every chance you get, but it does mean that you fully notice some of the potentially negative

influences from their traditional thinking. I strongly believe that the traditional Asian definition of success that limits the imagination of the younger generation to only a few, narrow career paths is neither sensible nor scalable. My personal definition of success is “realizing your greatest self-potential regardless of profession and impacting society in a positive way.” It’s completely acceptable if your own definition is different but my point is, you must come up with it yourself and not just be a slave to what others tell you to believe. The world is desperately in need of innovative, independent minds who can think “outside the box” and challenge the status quo to solve problems that have been plaguing industries such as education, environment, science, public health and more. However, trying to plug every unique child into the traditional cookie-cutter mindset of “success” will kill the younger generations’ innovation, creativity and willingness to take risks. We must instead encourage them to test their limitless possibilities of impacting the world while taking their own uniqueness into account. Asian-American parents initially brought their children to America to give us a better education that in turn gave us many possibilities and freedom of thought. Then somehow, those same parents managed to limit our meaning of success to only a few paths. It just doesn’t make any sense. We, the millennial and post-millennial generations, have to correct this going forward.

Lastly, I urge you to avoid status-obsession as much as possible. Many of us in modern societies have been becoming overly obsessed with how we come across to others. For example, we tend to compare ourselves based on all sorts of arbitrary measures like the number of Instagram followers, impressive job titles, where we live or how many cool travel destinations we’ve been to. Granted, all of us are born with an inherent human drive to become an es-

teemed member of society, and the Maslow's Hierarchy of Needs states that all human beings share this "esteem-based need" for status, respect and recognition by others. However, just like lust, gluttony or other human desires that can become obsessive if untamed, the desire for status and recognition by others may work the same way. Long-term happiness cannot come from external validation of your ego alone, especially if you lack internal validation that can only come from inside you. Inner peace and self-love do not magically appear when you suddenly get a million new followers on Instagram, move to a better-sounding job, or win a million dollars. In fact, excessive public attention and celebrity-status can often drive people into high stress over time, as evidenced by the frequency of high-profile celebrities who end up with mental breakdowns or substance abuse problems. I urge you to be aware of our human obsession for social status as much as possible, and learn to tame it when necessary.

If every ambitious, smart young person were to flock to only the most glamorous spotlight to be considered "successful" in the eyes of others, none of the darkness of our world would be resolved. In fact, throughout history, it was those who were unafraid of being judged by others and dedicated their lives to making the world a better place who eventually became shining examples to the rest of us. So don't just jump to the next biggest spotlight or be disappointed that you are not in the spotlight today. The light that is found in darkness often shines the brightest.

If you are not directly impacted by depression yourself but know of a close friend or family member who may be suffering from major depression, the answer to their suffering is not always simple or straight-forward, as I've mentioned frequently in this

book. Every case of depression may be unique based on the individual. So, harshly judging someone suffering from depression and yelling at them to “snap out of it” is not going to help. Instead, I suggest that you become a supportive partner in their journey by assisting them in the overwhelming puzzle to understand their own brain. Sometimes, it will consist of making sure they attend their therapy sessions with an experienced psychotherapist. Sometimes, it will consist of reminding them the importance of getting enough physical exercise, stopping harmful habits and noticing their rumination. Sometimes, it will help the most when you act as a non-judgmental sounding board so that they can open up to you about any distressing emotions. Remind them the theory of positive upward spirals and downward depressive spirals. Be a ray of hope for them and spend time with them. You never know if the right answer to their depression is just around the corner.

Although my sister is no longer alive, her dreams live on through me and the people she touched. In her final letter to me, Katie wrote, “Believe in yourself, Terry. Go for your biggest dreams.” I intend to follow through on that promise to Katie. I pray you will do the same. I wish you peace, love and true success.



# Acknowledgements

I dedicate this book to Katie Bu, my older sister who passed away in 2006, and all of you who were kind enough to support the publishing of this book. I also give my sincerest gratitude to my mother as well as family and friends who helped me recover from depression. I am also grateful to Dr. Chad Ebesutani for his support and interview. Last but not least, I thank God.



# A Letter to Korean Readers

한국 독자 분들에게,

안녕하세요, 여러분. 2005년도에 “당찬 가족의 성공 유학 프로젝트” 라는 책을 누나와 어머니와 함께 출판한 부성현이라고 합니다. 거의 15년이란 세월이 지난 지금에도 저의 인스타그램을 찾아주시고 독후감을 전해주시는 분들이 계셔서 큰 감사의 말씀드리고 싶습니다.

저희의 책을 읽어주시고 응원해 주셨던 분들에게 인사드리고 싶었고 저희들의 근황을 전해드리고 싶었습니다. 중학교 1학년 때 커네티컷의 시골 동네에서 집 컴퓨터 앞에 앉아 웹사이트를 만들고 책을 쓰던 날들을 생각하면 감회가 새롭습니다. 아마 그때 저희들을 따뜻하게 응원해주셨던 많은 분들의 덕택에 제가 이 두 번째 책을 쓰게 될 수 있었다고 생각합니다.

경아 누나의 소식을 들으시고 충격을 받으실 분들도 있으리라 생각됩니다. 15년 전 책을 출판할 시절의 경아 누나는 그나마 건강하고 최선을 다해서 살아가는 대학생이었습니다. 어머니께서는 누나의 죽음 후에 마음고생을 많이 하셨고 요즘에도 누나 생각으로 눈물을 흘리십니다. 하지만 어머니는 저와 함께 생계를 유지해 나가기 위해서 심적 고통과 씨름하시면서도 지난 15년간 곳곳이 직장생활을 하셨습니다. 저와 누나가 옛날 썼던 그대로 어머니는 여전히 저희 가족의 슈퍼

우먼입니다.

저는 지난 8년간 뉴욕의 맨해튼에서 직장을 다니며 살고 있습니다. 누나가 죽은 뒤 저는 커네티컷 Amity 고등학교를 졸업하였고 UNC Chapel Hill 대학교에서 좋은 경험을 많이 얻었습니다. 누나를 잃은 저에게 대학교에서 사귀어 새로운 친구들은 너무나도 소중한 보물이었고 저의 새로운 가족이 되었습니다. 제가 경아 누나와 비슷한 우울증 증세를 나타내기 시작했을 때 대학교 친구들이 저를 간호해 주었습니다. 그때의 친구들이야말로 정말 저의 생명의 은인입니다.

저는 이 책 안에서 한국인, 그리고 아시아계 미국인들이 함께 겪고 있는 사회 문제들을 언급했습니다. 대한민국은 지금 세계적으로 자살률이 가장 높은 OECD 국가중 하나입니다. 저는 제 누나의 자살과 한국 청년들의 자살 뉴스를 들으면서 이 현상이 조금이라도 연결되어 있는 것이 아닐까라는 의문을 가졌습니다. 경아 누나의 죽음과 우울증을 직접 겪은 후에 저희들의 사고방식, 자신감 그리고 자존감이 건강한 정신상태를 유지하기 위해서 얼마나 중요한지 뼈저리게 느꼈기 때문에 모두를 위해서 이 책을 쓰고 싶었습니다. 심적으로 앓고 자살 소망을 가지고 있는 청년들을 돕기 위해서는 그들의 마음속 안에 있는 내적 세계를 먼저 치료해 줘야 합니다. 학교나 직장의 경쟁 속에서 이기는 것만이 인생의 전부가 아니라고 깨닫게 해주고 대신 사랑과 마음의 평안의 씨앗을 심어주어야 합니다. 악플에 시달리던 유명한 연예인들이 자살을 하는 현상도 직시해야 되는 문제입

니다. 대중의 정신건강과 연예인들에 향한 악플이 연결되어 있는 가능성이 있지 않을까 추측됩니다.

이 책에서 말씀드렸듯이 앞으로 일어날 사회의 “성공”이란 단어의 의미는 저희들 밀레니얼 세대와 그 이후의 세대들이 새롭게 만들어 나가야 한다고 생각합니다. 테크놀로지와 인터넷의 발전으로 세계 어디서나 지식을 터득할 수 있는 무궁무진한 가능성을 가진 장래의 세상에서 “성공”하는 이들은 돈, 혹은 사회적 위치에만 집착하지는 않을 것입니다. 자기 자신이 가진 독특한 재능과 열정을 발휘시켜 과거에 상상하지 못했던 가능성을 창조해나가고 새로운 진리를 발굴해나가는 자유로운 이들의 세계가 될 것이라 강하게 믿는 바입니다.

혹시 오늘날 미국이나 타지에서 유학, 이민생활을 하고 계시는 분들 중에서 우울증이나 자괴감 때문에 고통을 겪고 계신다면 저한테 꼭 연락해주세요. 타지의 낯선 사회 안에서 새로운 문화에 적응해 나가며 생활해나가는 것은 너무나도 어려운 일입니다. 하지만 의지할 수 있는 좋은 커뮤니티를 찾으시고 건강한 정신상태를 유지하기 위해서 좋은 생활 습관을 부지런하게 실천해나가시면 충분히 가능한 일입니다. 아무리 실수하거나 실패하셔도 자기 자신을 사랑하고 포기하지 않는 정신을 잃지 마시기 바랍니다. 자기 자신을 향한 인내심과 믿음과 사랑이 우울증을 극복하는 열쇠가 되고 반드시 진정한 성공을 여러분에게 선물할 것이라 믿습니다.

다시 한번 감사드립니다.

글쓴이

부성현 올림

# About the Author

Terry Bu is an author of a self-help family autobiography titled *Study Abroad Success Diaries of a Daring Family* (당찬 가족의 성공 유학 프로젝트) published in South Korea in 2005. His family immigrated to the U.S. in 2001 from Seoul and lived in Orange, Connecticut for 7 years. Terry graduated from the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill in 2011 and has since been living in the New York City area. Terry has worked in software engineering and performed stand-up comedy in NYC for 4+ years. Please feel free to reach out to him on his Instagram at @terrybu.



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